Electric Tapestry

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28400790.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Entrapta & Imp (She-Ra), Hordak & Imp (She-Ra), Minor or Background Relationship(s), Cobalt/Grizzlor (She-Ra), Cobalt & Entrapta (She-Ra)

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Part 1 of Break the Cycle

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by bishonenrockmysocks

Summary

In the mad rush to stop the Heart of Etheria from going off and save the planet from an invading army, more than a few stories slipped to the wayside in favor of more pressing matters. That was okay though- Entrapta was used to not being a priority and entirely unsurprised by these events; she'd manage her grief and anger on her own just like she always did.

And then? Then she was going to go find her lab partner and shake him until he gave her some damn answers.

Let's pull back the curtain just a bit and see what Entrapta was up to during the end of Season 4...

~~Updates Tuesdays and Thursdays~~
Complete! See you all again soon for Part 2!

The neon beckons me beyond its ghostly light

Thump.

Entrapta shifted.

Thud.

She groaned and curled a little tighter.

Thunk.

"Nooooo…" A hand poked out from a nest of hair to wave dismissively at the sound. "Go awaaaay."

Thonk.

"Five more minuuutes!"

Thud.

"Imp, come *on*," she groused. "We can get snacks *later*."

Entrapta rolled over, rubbing her face deeper into her hair.

Thu-tunk.

"Uuuhhg! He's totally right, you've been spoiled rotten, you little pest." she mumbled. Maybe if she covered her ears she wouldn't- nope, there goes another one, loud and sudden enough to make her heart jump and speed up slightly. She groaned and started unwinding her hair from around herself. "Alright, alright already! I'm up, I'm-"

Entrapta propped herself up on an elbow and froze as her vision cleared.

"Oh."

Fleshy techno organic walls, dull light, large purple window, semi-soft floor, humid warmth- the interior of her robot-elemental hybrid friend.

Beast Island, not the Fright Zone.

"Right."

Thonk.

She shot a withering gaze at the offending noise. The pookas. *Again*.

Entrapta sighed in disgust as another blob of brown impacted at the window, willing herself not to flinch or startle. She scrubbed at her face with her free hand and groaned. It had taken a few encounters, but once the pookas had realized Misty was too fierce an opponent to take on- even at full swarm- and they'd experienced just how tensile and dexterous Entrapta's hair could be, they'd given up on their hunt and settled for merely harassing them instead.

Their latest trick, evidently, was throwing balls of mud at Misty's windshield.

Delightful.

At least they still knew better than to actually approach them.

Ignoring another splatter of mud, Entrapta shifted out from the narrow space she'd been sleeping and climbed into the internal structure she'd taken to using as a pilot's chair. Misty stirred slightly as well, uttering a soft questioning sound that vibrated through the cavity Entrapta occupied.

"Hey girl, all good?"

Misty vibrated once more, affirmatively this time.

“Great,” she said through a yawn. “Sorry about the pookas. You wanna give them a little chase off real quick?”

Entrapta’s entire world bounced up and down briefly as the creature nodded and bounded into motion. Thankfully, despite her lumbering size and significant gait, Misty was as careful of her passenger as ever and Entrapta settled back into her chair to finish waking up.

She was hungry, no surprise there. Thirsty too. The canteen she’d salvaged from the skiff’s emergency kit was nearly empty again and she’d need to either find another source of potable water or at least water that was reasonably safe for her to boil in order to refill it. There was always the option of attempting to retake her previous camp and the water well she’d excavated there but that meant driving off any scruffers still around and there was no telling when they’d come back and fight her for it again. No, that’d probably be more hassle than it was worth. Maybe she could check the First Ones temple again? See if there was a hidden cache she’d missed or the resources to create a purifier?

Uhg. Her eyes hurt. Right there, just at the bridge of her nose and spreading out across her eye sockets. Her neck was tight too and she could feel the beginnings of a tension headache creeping up the back of her skull. She’d really been banking on that nap clearing some of that up, but no such luck. At least her feet weren’t sore anymore, so that was good.

She absently dug her recorder out and clicked it on.

“Beast Island log, tide cycle...36? Is it still 36? The end of 36? Sure, let’s go with that. The nap didn’t really help. Headache intensity mostly just shifted rather than lessening and I’m still not sure if the issue is dehydration or the signal inducing migraine-like symptoms.”

She sighed and chewed at her lip for a moment.

"I...had that dream again. I really wish it would just stop already." Entrapta slumped back and closed her eyes. "If dreams are supposed to be the mind's way of testing out wild scenarios and preparing for danger then I really don't know why my subconscious seems to be so fixated on this. It's too late to change anything and all the hindsight in the world isn't going to make hi- it won't make me any more wan- uhg. It doesn't matter. Coulda, woulda, shoulda, but *didn't*. Dwelling on it won't advance my research *or* get me delicious snacks to eat and I wish my brain would just get that through it's thick skull."

She paused for a moment, opening her eyes and scrunching her face to squint at her own words.

"I don't think that statement works..."

Misty loped to a gentle halt and Entrapta reached a tendril of hair out to stroke the creature's interior wall. She crooned in delight and a large hand came into view as it began wiping away the offending sludge obscuring her window lens.

"Any luck on that new signal pattern we registered?" Entrapta's voice strained as she stretched her arms over her head. Misty cooed and a holoscreen popped up a moment later. The scientist hummed and leaned forward to read, rolling her shoulders and trying her best not to think about the tight pulling sensation in her back or how much a patch of it still itched and burned.

"Hmmm. Still unable to determine the exact source or nature of the new signal frequency Misty picked up earlier," she said into her recorder. "As previously noted, I'd hoped it was coming from off the island due to its similarity to the data transfer stylings typically favored by Maker's Guild tech but I'm starting to suspect it's more likely a vocal call from one of the local fauna I haven't encountered yet or a new frequency originating from the island structure itself. Anecdotal evidence suggests the signal's source adapts to the island residents in whatever way best facilitates the decommissioning process and either works in conjunction with them, such as with the pookas and scruffers, or in opposition, like

the desiccated remains of that draconic creature I spotted a few cycles ago. That means there's a real possibility that this new frequency is another of the island's attempts to work me into its ecosystem and 'figure me out' so to speak."

Entrapta snorted. *Good luck with that.*

Another holoscreen popped up depicting a new data set and an accompanying frequency reading overlaid on a roughly charted map.

"Huh. Speaking of, it seems the signal is honing in on a specific location again. I haven't picked up readings this strong in the fourth strata before- it's nearly as severe as at the center of strata one. This lends further support to my hypothesis that the signal targets and concentrates on individuals. So then, what is it tracking? Perhaps someone new has arriv-" Entrapta bit her lip and closed her eyes to take a deep breath. *Don't*.

She exhaled long and slow and opened her eyes again.

"No. It's much more likely to be that weird man who hoards all the rations. Or maybe a razorfin? One of those would definitely need a signal frequency that strong to take it down." A hair hand came up to stroke her chin. "Or maaaaybe a new, previously dormant First Ones mechanism has activated in response to my experiment the other day?"

Misty made a questioning sound and Entrapta smiled.

"Yeah girl, we probably should just go and see for ourselves instead of postulating forever. It woooould be dangerous though...but it *is* pretty close by...oh but I really should just focus on resupplying...but on the other hand we could- oh!"

A third screen popped up displaying a graph depicting a sudden and prolonged surge of magical energy.

"Ooooooohhhhhhhhh look at *that* Misty! Oh we have *got* to go see what's causing it!"

If the hybrid had eyebrows and Entrapta had not been sitting in what was effectively its mouth, she was sure from the skeptical sound she made that Misty would be raising them.

"I know, I knoooow, it could be a trap or some kind of predator or both. But ooh, we've never seen something like that on the island before and what kind of scientist would I be if I didn't go investigate?"

The cabin jostled and vibrated slightly as a low rumbling chuckle emanated from the creature. Entrapta pumped a fist in celebration as Misty began moving in a solid stride towards the energy source.

"Yeah! That's my girl!"

She didn't rightly know what was waiting for them, but of all the possible explanations and theories that ran through her head, the one she didn't consider was them catching up with their pack of pookas from before and running into *Adora? And...Bow?*

A staining trophy of the battles I've survived

Chapter Notes

> Thank you all so much for the very warm reception and kind comments. I haven't written like this in *years,* so it really means a lot!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It took awhile but, once the initial awe at the sight of the glorious display of First Ones archaeological record before her wore off, Entrapta realized she was dead tired. She sipped delicately at her water (had bottled water always tasted this good?) and nodded along as the others sitting on the floor around her chattered excitedly. She'd lost track of the conversation ages ago, too worn down to focus effectively, especially with her train of thought being continuously disrupted by the birdhorse's nonstop nonsense and the scraggly man's sudden interjections.

When Bow had informed her and...uh...okay, she so couldn't actually remember the weird man's name but she was pretty sure he was a king of some kind so that ought to count for something, right? Anyway, when Bow told them that it would take several hours to get back to Brightmoon, Entrapta had not minded one bit.

Frankly, there was a lot going on and it had apparently been longer than she'd realized since she'd last been around people. Additionally, she'd completely lost what little grounded routine and stability she'd established back on the island and, while it was nice to not need to be on the lookout for danger anymore, she had absolutely no idea what was waiting for her back in Brightmoon or how any of it was going to go or what anyone was going to say or what they expected of her and-

Entrapta took a long, slow breath and another sip of water.

If she was to be completely honest, Entrapta was pretty sure she could have gotten the ship to go faster. If what Hor- *ahem*, rather, if what she'd been told about the metrics of space and its traversal was true, then getting to Brightmoon ought to be a question of minutes rather than hours. And yet...the idea of a couple hours to decompress in relative safety sounded nice. There was so much to take in and think about, so many things that had happened that needed to be recontextualized and, apparently, a lot of events that needed catching up on as well. Besides, she'd been gone for nearly ten whole months! What difference would a couple more hours make anyway?

Once they'd gotten underway and Bow had pulled out a sack of prepacked food and water and started passing it out to the group, she'd been downright giddy. Real food! Complex carbohydrates that weren't in expired, freeze dried packets! Leafy greens! Meat that came from domesticated herd animals instead of whatever bug or questionable creature she could find and hunt herself! Dairy- real, actual *dairy*!

There was so very much to love about Beast Island but ooooohh, in this exact moment, it paled in comparison to the joy of a fresh sandwich.

Her good mood carried her through the inevitably serious conversation about what had transpired since hers and the king's separate exiles and she was mostly finished with her meal by the time Bow and Adora got them up to more recent events. Entrapta'd been secretly grateful for that small stroke of fortune because, by the time they'd started talking about an under cover agent from the Horde and the sacking of Salineas, the apple slice in her mouth had turned ashy and mealy. When the birdhorse had started to chime in with all kinds of needlessly cruel comments about the Horde in that gratingly loud voice of his, she'd been more than happy to sacrifice the rest of her uneaten apple to shut him up.

Thankfully, conversation soon shifted to Glimmer and her new appointment as Queen and Entrapta'd been safely able to let her

thoughts drift to better pastures. Or, well, she tried to at least. She'd spent every day on Beast Island avoiding thoughts that evoked disquieting feelings but now that she was away from it, for some reason she couldn't seem to dodge the stabbing pangs of grief as easily. Maybe it was because everything was so much quieter now and that made everything else infinitely louder too? She'd gotten so used to the signal whispering in her ear. After awhile, it had even become an almost pleasant white noise helping to drown out the unhelpful thoughts so she could focus on the things that mattered: her research, and not dying long enough for her to *continue* her research. Honestly, it hadn't been until Bow and Adora had shown up and started meddling that the soft background fuzz had intensified into a dull roar that drowned out even those priorities.

She combed at her hair anxiously, flecks of dried mud breaking away to litter the floor around her.

"Something wrong?"

"Hm?" Entrapta looked up to see Adora staring back, an encouraging smile on her face. Behind her Bow, the king, and the birdhorse jabbered on, unaware.

"You kind of look like you don't feel very well." Adora pointed to Entrapta's hands and tilted her head. "You're not hurt are you?"

Entrapta looked back and forth between the hair she was holding and Adora. "Oh! No, hahaha!" She plastered a wide grin on her face. "I was just thinking about how gunky my hair feels and how nice it'll be to finally get it clean again."

She cringed internally. Her smile was much too forced and it was such a weak lie; Imp wouldn't have bought it for an instant and Horda-

Ahg, she had to stop thinking about them.

"Oooooh, yeah!" Adora grimaced sympathetically. "That's probably pretty uncomfortable, huh?"

Entrapta curled an encrusted tendril between them to form a misshapen heart silhouette. “It does make things a tiiiny bit more difficult.”

“Hmmmmm, oh wait- I know! Lemme show you the bathroom. There’s a thing in there that I *think* might be a shower?” Adora started to stand up. “Although, I don’t actually know if it works, come to think of it.” She rubbed her chin for a moment and shrugged, holding out a hand to Entrapta. “Well, even if it doesn’t, I do know the sink does, so at least there’s that?”

She took Adora’s hand and stood up as well.

“Oooh, that’d be fantastic!”

Calling over her shoulder nonchalantly to the boys that they’d be back soon, Adora led Entrapta out of the control room and through another section of the ship.

“Well,” Adora said, scratching the back of her head as a door opened onto a small room. “Here we are. Not much compared to Brightmoon but...y’know, gets the job done.”

“Are you kidding?” Entrapta called as she took a step inside and looked around. “This is great!”

“Hey, uh, Entrapta?”

She hummed back distractedly as she tested the sink.

“You sure you’re okay?”

She paused and very nearly slammed her mask down over her face. With a bit of forced cheeriness, Entrapta smiled and tilted her head at Adora.

“Of course! Why? Should I not be?”

“Oh! No- wait, yes? I just mean, uh, y’know…” Entrapta waited as Adora fidgeted and laughed nervously for a moment. “What with

everything that's happened and Beast Islaaand…"

Entrapta waved a hair hand dismissively.

"Oh don't worry about that."

"Huh? Really?"

Entrapta nodded. "I told you- Beast Island was great! I just spent ten months on the biggest collection of First Ones artifacts modern Etherians have ever encountered and the whole trip took my research further than I ever dreamed of achieving! I used to spend months at a time digging for artifacts and considered myself lucky if I found even a shard of a data crystal larger than a centimeter! But now?" She clasped her hands together and sighed dreamily. "Now I'm on the best preserved example of First Ones daily life, complete with a working AI and a mostly intact database, *and* I'm about to take a shower the same way this ship's pilot did a thousand years ago!" She lifted herself onto her hair and wiggled animatedly. "Isn't that amazing? I get to experience history *first hand!"*

"Hah, I suppose you're right," Adora replied with a warm smile. "I guess I'll leave you to it then. Shout if you need anything!"

"Sure thing!" Entrapta waved at the other girl as she retreated down the hallway and out of sight.

Alone at last, Entrapta pressed the button to close and lock the door. She slumped against it and hung her head, closing her eyes and carefully counting her breaths.

Sorry Adora, I know you just want to help.

She hadn't exactly lied to Adora; she did want to get clean and the idea of trying out a First Ones shower was nearly breathtaking to her! But...well, like everything else right now, the cubical sitting innocuously against the opposite wall seemed downright *daunting*. There was so much of the space craft she wanted to test and try and explore and she was legitimately eager to dive into its code

and take a peek at its mechanics, but a properly thorough survey could easily take weeks and as much as she desperately wanted to get started on the project *right this instant*, she knew it was also infinitely more than she could handle at the moment.

Entrapta scrubbed at her face and eyed the sink through her fingers.

A sink bath would be a great deal more hassle than the shower and it would take longer and make a bigger mess, but the fact that she not only knew that it worked but also *how* it worked made the prospect seem almost worth it. On the other hand, it would also expend a lot of energy she really didn't have to spare. Would the potential effort required to learn to operate the shower be more or less than the sink?

This was all assuming, of course, that the mechanics of bathing were significantly different across culture and time. Would it be though? Bathing habits were pretty varied among the species on Etheria, but the plumbing itself was generally consistent. Was this like the wheel in that there are only so many ways you can invent it before you've effectively perfected the design?

She supposed she could also just...ask? Could the computer even hear her in here? Would it think she was stupid for getting worked up over operating such a simple device?

To her great relief, the computer *could* in fact hear her when she tentatively spoke up and it was more than helpful in guiding her without a trace of the judgement she knew better than to expect from anything other than organic beings.

The pipes groaned and clanged momentarily as she turned the stream on, the water itself coming out in spits and glugs as centuries of stale air and built up debris was forced out. Entrapta was half considering testing the water's safety by the time the pressure steadied out and the liquid finally began to run clear. Just as she was debating what to do with her clothes and if she should attempt to wash them in the shower as well, the computer

helpfully slid open a panel in the adjoining wall and directed her to hang them on the provided hooks for cleaning. Awestruck and emboldened by her success so far, she dumped the contents of her pockets on the floor and eagerly relinquished everything but her mask and gloves to the alcove.

She wiped away a fine layer of grit that had settled on the sink counter and started disentangling her tools and the other, more important objects she kept in her hair. As she piled them carefully on the surface, she caught sight of her reflection in the mirror above the sink and paused to consider it.

Huh. So, the gashes on her jaw from the giant mantis had scarred after all.

She'd lost weight too, which she supposed made sense; sporadic, hidden caches of expired ration bars and carefully portioned out mantis meat could only do so much when every day was a feat of survival. There were dark circles under her eyes and a subtle new sharpness to her face that she attributed to the undereating. She tilted her head left and right, observing how the light caught on her cheekbones; did it lend her a more authoritative appearance? Make her seem more stern and impressive like H-

Entrapta carefully set her mask down and tugged her gloves off to better examine the myriad of cuts and bruises that lined her arms and legs. Under the much brighter electrical lighting, she was relieved to see that most of her older injuries, including the finger she'd nearly broken, seemed to have healed alright. Having said that, she was particularly glad for the chance to better clean out the deep slice in her shoulder one of the spider creatures had pegged her with several days prior.

She gingerly poked at the inflamed skin, coaxing out and draining the semi-hard mass of liquid that had built up under the scab until it seeped clear. It would be good to get some clean water on it but even she had to admit, it might be wise to visit a healer in Brightmoon. As much as she generally distrusted magical methods of healing when the far more reliable, scientifically backed

methods of the Western Regions such as Dryl and the Fright Zone were available, she really wasn't keen on seeing the cut get infected and there was no telling what corrosive or toxic substances the spider creature potentially secreted. It was healing well enough for now, but there was no point in taking chances when there were sensible alternatives just because of some (mostly) irrational hang ups.

As she twisted and turned to better look at her shoulder in the dusty mirror she caught sight of a vicious blotch on her back and gasped. A part of her screeched in panic to look away, but a grim fascination compelled her to turn more fully towards the mirror and stare at the fresh scar. It was the first time she'd properly seen it since Catra had stunned her and it was easily as thick and ugly as it had felt, badly healed and sporting marks that suggested it would need to be seen by a healer as well if she didn't want long term complications. She'd known at the time the first aid kit she'd gathered from the crashed skiff's emergency supplies hadn't been enough but she really hadn't had many other options. Even with the kit, her materials had been sorely limited and she'd had no choice but to rely on her overalls to help bind the gauze to the wound, increasing the likelihood of fibers from the partially burnt and melted portion of her shirt mixing in. Now that she could actually see the burn mark in all of its hideous glory, she knew without a shred of doubt that she'd been nothing short of lucky it hadn't gotten infected or worse.

Breathing hard and gripping the counter to steady herself, Entrapta turned away from the sight and willed the shorter locks of hair that bound the rest to unwind so it would curtain around her and hide the brutal injury. Equal parts nausea and bitter anger welled up in her and she shook with its intensity. She took a few more shuddering breaths and stomped into the shower cubical, a part of her pleased by the sudden shock of still too cold water against her skin.

Luck. Blind luck and the clumsy efforts of a pair of teenagers, their pet, and a wild man they'd just met had been the only thing that had saved her. If Scorpia really was waiting for them back in

Brightmoon, then why hadn't she come to Beast Island with Bow and Adora? And how was Entrapta even supposed to face the other woman in the first place? She'd been on that damn island for nearly a *year* and Scorpia had sat on the information the whole time, twiddling her pincers and playing dumb while Entrapta fought for her life. What stung even worse was the fact that when she finally *had* decided to do something, Scorpia had gone to the *Alliance* instead of Hordak, despite knowing *exactly* how Entrapta felt about both of them.

But then again, from the sounds of things, maybe she'd been wrong about Hordak the whole time too.

Entrapta chewed viciously at the inside of her cheek as she scrubbed at her hair, flexing and twisting the strands as best she could in the water to try and soften the hard, tacky shell of grime that clumped them together so miserably.

He'd actually done it.

Entrapta squeezed her eyes shut and chewed at her cheek harder.

She could hardly believe it, but what reason would Bow and Adora have to lie?

Despite everything, Hordak had made the pulse bots after all.

They'd agreed, hadn't they? The pulse bots were too dangerous to use, too extreme and far better suited to a bloodier and more brutal style of warfare than the one Etheria employed. Introducing them would be like starting an avalanche- kicking off an arms race that would inevitably lead to the kinds of horrifyingly destructive methods that ought to remain forever in the realm of theory. The things she'd seen buried in Hordak's archives- liquid fire and weaponized nuclear fission, biochemical clouds and engineered plagues- she'd been so relieved when he'd responded to her cringing terror with a degree of open discomfort he seldom admitted to.

So why? Why would he open that door and risk the cascade of mutual destruction that would come spilling out?

Had everything been a lie? Had he used her just like everyone else?

Her hands slowed and she opened her eyes to watch the curling swirls of brownish green water at her feet.

Everything had been so much easier when she'd thought Hordak had already left Etheria. The sting of being left behind was familiar and copeable, but knowing that he was still on Etheria and that he hadn't come for her? That he'd intensified the war instead? That was almost too much. It hurt in a way completely different from what she was used to, like a wound ripped open and left to fester.

Why? Why hadn't he gone yet? The portal had been opened, surely the signal had gotten through, so why wasn't he with his people?

Not even in her wildest dreams had she actually dared to believe he was still here. But he was and he hadn't come for her. Had he even known where she was? He was the lord of the Fright Zone- he *had* to have known! Hordak made it his *business* to know important things like that! Unless...unless she hadn't rated as important. What if he'd purposely left her there? What if he'd always intended to send her to Beast Island when the portal was done? What if he'd decided she knew too much and was a threat? What if he'd- he'd- what if he'd found out what Catra had done and congratulated her on a job well done?

A wave of unexpected nausea hit her and she braced an arm against the cool tile wall, trying to breathe as slow and evenly as she could.

No.

No, he wouldn't.

She *had* to believe he wouldn't have done that. Hordak was many things but he was *not* a liar. It had to be something else.

Maybe he didn't know after all? Or something? But how could he not? Scorpia had been there! She wasn't a liar either! Surely Scorpia had told Hordak Catra had sent her to Beast Island, right? But...then why did she defect to the rebellion? Did Hordak not believe her? Threaten her?

That made no sense; Hordak *liked* Scorpia. Even if she wasn't sure that he ever said so to Scorpia herself, Entrapta knew for a fact that Hordak said plenty of complimentary things about Scorpia to her and Commander Cobalt. For someone as withdrawn and guarded as Hordak, that was like a mountaintop declaration of eternal devotion.

The more she thought about it, yes, she was *definitely* sure she'd heard them talk about how reliable and earnest Scorpia was. Yeah, okay, Scorpia gets clumsy and chatty when she's nervous, but so does Entrapta and that had never bothered Hordak! Besides- *everyone* knows how hard Scorpia tries, even if she isn't always the greatest at what she's doing. There was that meeting she'd overheard too- the one between Hordak and Grizzlor happened upon while she'd been rewiring the Fright Zone's electrical grid; they'd agreed Scorpia was making good progress! On what, Entrapta hadn't been entirely sure, but it was clear they were looking forward to her future within the Horde. She'd been so proud of Scorpia- there weren't many people who impressed Hordak and the top Force Captains like that and they'd been smiling and nodding as they spoke.

So no, there was absolutely no way Hordak had threatened her. Hordak would have listened to Scorpia; he's patient (...well, mostly) and he takes other people's advice and opinions into consideration before making decisions. Even if he hadn't believed Scorpia, he would have at least investigated! So then had Catra threatened Scorpia too? Probably. But Hordak would have protected Scorpia! Ensured she was safe while he determined what was going on. Scorpia knew that, right?

Perhaps not.

Ten months.

Ten whole months.

Maybe Hordak knew but Catra had threatened him? That seemed...hm. What if he'd sent Scorpia to seek help because she was the most likely to succeed with the Alliance and he couldn't go himself? That seemed so incredibly unlikely to her, but Catra was fast and clever and Hordak was surprisingly vulnerable and easy to push around; it stood to reason that if Catra figured out how to deactivate Hordak's exoskeleton, he'd be hard pressed to stop her. Hadn't Adora and Bow mentioned that Catra and Hordak seemed to be working closely together now? Unlike Scorpia, Hordak did *not* like Catra, but if she was blackmailing him, what choice would he have but to do as she asked?

Maybe he was hurt or his condition had taken a turn for the worse. Entrapta had all the proof she needed seared into her back that Catra didn't mind hurting her friends, so there was no reason to doubt that she'd make an aggressive move on Hordak just because he was her boss. Besides, hadn't Catra tried already with the whole Shadow Weaver thing? Hadn't Hordak warned her that Catra was dangerous? And, like the overly trusting idiot she was, she'd brushed his concerns off and pressured Hordak to send Catra on an expedition for them instead.

Entrapta growled softly and scrubbed hard at her scalp. Her chipped and splitting fingernails left small scratches in their wake that, although accidental, provided an unexpectedly nice tingling sensation.

She hated how much like wishful thinking this felt and she could positively see herself flailing wildly and grasping at the most flimsy of justifications and excuses her imagination could come up with-anything to avoid the crueler and darker truths staring her straight in the eye. It was stupid and embarrassing and pathetic and yet,

despite knowing better, the ceaseless litany of what ifs kept coming.

She wasn't a complete moron, she knew Hordak had sent Catra to the Crimson Wastes with the expectation that she wouldn't return, but still, it was hard not to admit that none of this would have ever happened if she'd just let Hordak send Catra to Beast Island like he'd wanted to in the first place.

Hah, she'd have liked to see *Catra* of all people try to survive on Beast Island for a *week*. Sure, she was tough but that didn't mean anything; Entrapta had seen the island take down creatures far faster and more resilient than Catra. Even if she *was* good enough to survive, she wasn't magically skilled or particularly gifted or even tech savvy enough to engineer a way off the island. There was no way she'd have ever made it out without help and, unlike her, Entrapta was pretty sure no one would have cared enough to bother with some half or even full assed rescued mission for Catra's sake.

Hm. What a strangely comforting yet morbid thought.

Entrapta sighed and sank to the floor of the shower. She pulled the heavy mass of her hair over her uninjured shoulder and rested her forehead against the shower wall so the water could hit her back and neck. She moaned a little as the finally warm water hit her bad shoulder, enjoying how it stung in comparison to the relaxing effect the rest of her back was experiencing.

She'd avoided thinking about him for so long, but now that the door had been ripped from its hinges, it was hard to ignore what was waiting for her beyond the threshold.

She missed Hordak horribly. It felt stupid to be so attached to another person but she couldn't help it. There was such a high likelihood that he'd used or abandoned her and yet she still wanted to see him again anyway. There was just... *something* about the bull-headed, cantankerous man that she felt magnetically drawn to, something that she couldn't describe that

had nothing to do with his knowledge or resources or cybernetics. Those things were nice perks, yes, of course, but that wasn't what fueled her inexplicable urge to rush to the Fright Zone the moment they landed and shake him until he told her what was going on.

A lot of things would have made her time on Beast Island more enjoyable, proper supplies and equipment in particular, but somehow the thing she'd desperately wanted most of all had been her lab partner. No matter how many groundbreaking discoveries she'd made, no matter what she'd invented or repaired, none of it ever quite thrilled her like it should have. The rush of joy always felt just a little lacking, the surge of excited dot connecting always seemed to wear off faster than before. Every career first, every major milestone, every perspective defying discovery had felt like it had been flawed, like something was wrong and it was preventing her from enjoying the results of her work to its fullest. And how many times had her thoughts tried to drift to Hordak? How many times had she started to ask him his opinion? How many times had she had to suppress the urge to call out for Imp to pass her a tool? When had she gotten so used to having them in her life that when they were gone she was reduced to a pathetic puddle on the floor?

Entrapta sniffed loudly.

Everything had been so much easier back in Dryl. Things had been quiet and comfortable and predictable in all the right ways. No one bothered her if she didn't want them to and she'd been able to work in peace without worrying about what other people thought. She'd been content back then, but then she'd opened herself up, made herself vulnerable again, and started caring about what other people felt and thought and did.

She'd forgotten all of her hard learned lessons, just like that, all because a girl with a First Ones sword showed up at her door along with a princess to a Queendom she knew better than to trust and a very sweet and flattering boy. Of *course* they'd asked

her to make weapons, that's what people did when they came to Dryl, and of *course* it had all been a fair weather arrangement.

But then there had been the Fright Zone and all kinds of people who *weren't* put off by her just being herself. Catra might have been keeping her around for conditional reasons, sure, but there had still been darling Scorpia and down to earth Cobalt and Grizzlor with his booming laughs and witty Octavia and Cookie who smelled funny but always had a new treat tucked away for her in the canteen and poor put upon Kyle with his complicated relationships and the brusque Adamantia who took every one of Entrapta's part requests as a new and engaging challenge and proudly grinned alongside her whenever they finished constructing her newest bot design.

And Hordak, oh *Hordak*; he'd been the greatest surprise of them all. The Fright Zone residents were one thing, but Hordak? He'd been *different*, he'd been *more.* She didn't just want to swap information with Hordak, she wanted to *impress* him. She'd wanted to live up to and exceed his standards. But it wasn't about approval, no- she wanted his excitement, his rare genuine smiles. Being around him didn't feel like an irritating waste of precious working time like it was around others and, as the weeks stretched into months, she found herself actively looking forward to seeing him each day and bitterly disappointed when their work time was interrupted by Hordak's other duties. Suddenly, before she'd even known what had happened, she discovered that she wanted to learn about him, get to know him. She didn't just want to be the same shallow sort of friends with him that she was with other people, she wanted him to feel comfortable enough around her to drop the conqueror persona and confide in her. She wanted to share with him her own fears and frustrations, her joys and successes. She wanted to share with him more of herself than she ever had with even her closest of companions. And now, as a direct result, she couldn't even properly enjoy her research without him there next to her.

Entrapta took in a shuddering breath and choked a little.

What would she do if he really didn't want to be her friend anymore?

Her eyes stung.

Could she really be content again in that secluded life she'd built for herself in Dryl?

Her vision blurred.

She *liked* being alone. Others always told her that was weird, that she belonged with people and how "healthy" and "normal" socializing was but she *enjoyed* the solitude. People were so much work and there was seldom any quantifiable benefit to being around them for long periods of time. She *knew* that, knew what an ultimately futile pursuit the whole thing was, and yet somehow she still kept forgetting. It was all just so much tidier to keep others at an arms' length.

A sob crawled its way up her chest and caught in her throat.

So why did the idea of moving on without Hordak feel so wretchedly lonely?

Entrapta wrapped her arms around herself and bent forward as the sob came loose. Her eyes clenched shut as the tears rolled down her cheeks and she wailed miserably. Her nose clogged and she could hardly breathe through her own moaning, the cries breaking apart into intermittent coughs and retching gags. Her body spasmed and ached and she only had enough presence of mind to spool a length of hair beneath her head to keep it above the water line as she laid down on the floor.

--

She hadn't really meant to, but she must have dozed off for at least a few minutes, because the next thing she was consciously aware of was how cold the water had gotten and the way her ankle was cramping and her hip was aching. She moved to sit up as best she could in the small space and scrubbed at her swollen

face; the headache was back and she was sorely tempted to drink some of the cold spray, stopped only by the reminder that there was no telling if the water was filtered well enough to be potable. Hair raising up to grip at anything it could to steady her, Entrapta stiffly stood and reached out to turn the water off.

She stood there numbly for a long moment, only now realizing she had no idea how she was going to get dry, when several long panels on each side of the shower opened up and began to gust her with air. She blinked and felt a distant echo of fascination at the efficiency and cleverness of the design but said nothing, opting instead to focus on twisting and wringing as much water out of her hair as she could before fanning it out in front of one of the blowers.

She threaded her fingers through the strands a few times and stepped out of the cubicle once satisfied that it had dried enough. Like the rest of her, it was worn and damaged from lack of care, the ends brittle and fraying from all the caustic substances it had come in contact with. The whole mess was dry and frizzing, the oil produced from her scalp nowhere near enough to properly coat the full length, and it was in desperate need of a proper combing and conditioning; she only hoped she'd get the opportunity soon.

Nevertheless, as the alcove that had taken her clothes opened up and offered them back to her, clean and pleasantly warm, there was a shadow of her old energy in each movement. Sure, her hair would require the full, obnoxiously long, multi-hour treatment to get it back to its usual luster, but at least she could feel it all again and move it freely without dragging around a bunch of unidentified sludge. And sure, there were still straining seams and holes forming in her clothes, but they were soft again and felt fresh and smooth against her skin.

Dressed once more, she stepped over to the sink and began methodically wiping down all of her tools and treasures, losing herself to the familiar comfort of the repetitive, mindless motions. Once satisfied, she carefully returned each of the items to their

respective pockets and hair strands. Finally, she pulled on her gloves and set her mask into place.

When she looked up in the mirror, she almost felt like herself again.

She took a deep breath and another one after that.

Entrapta eyed the door and wondered how long she'd been gone. Would they ask questions? She looked back to the mirror and attempted a wide grin. It still felt forced to her, but she'd practiced the expression so many times, she was sure none of them would be able to tell the difference.

"Come on Entrapta, you know how this goes. Never let them see you bleed and all that." She slapped her hands against her cheeks a few times and shook her head. "All you gotta do is smile and laugh just like they want you to. They saved you, remember? So they expect you to be grateful."

She took another deep breath and opened the door, stepping out into the ship's hallway. She retraced the route Adora had taken them on earlier and found her way soon enough back to the command bridge where the others waited.

She spotted Bow first, his back to them all as he stood at the control console, focused on the holographic globe it was projecting. Between them, the king was laying against the side of the birdhorse, evidently sleeping, while Adora was crouched next to him packing up what looked like...a first aid kit? Oh, yes, that seemed right, there was a bandage on his leg now.

Adora was the first to notice Entrapta's entrance and looked up with smile.

"Oh hey, you're back! Feeling better?"

Entrapta grinned back toothily.

“Oh yes!” She twisted and flexed her pig tails for Adora. “Much better!”

“Awesome. King Micah got bit by a pooka.” Adora stood and lightly shook the box in her hands. “How about you? Are you injured at all?” Adora grinned smugly. “Not to toot my own horn or anything, but I got the highest marks in first aid in my class during cadet training. Commander Cobalt’s a real stickler for stuff like safety and preparedness, so I can totally handle anything.”

Entrapta’s shoulder throbbed as she tilted her head to the side and rocked on her heels.

“Nope, all good!”

Chapter End Notes

> Look- if Darla can have thousand year old dehydrated protein slaw that is still somehow fit for humanoid consumption, she can have a functional shower and laundry facilities too. Also it conveniently explains the animation error where Entrapta’s hair and clothes are dirty on Beast Island but the moment they hit Brightmoon she’s perfectly clean and coiffed. Is it a necessary detail? No. Did I take advantage of it to indulge in a really dumb trope? *You bet your buttered biscuits I did.*
>
> Also, because this fandom is so endlessly inspiring and is nearly as responsible for this story as I am, I'd like to give credit to my fellow fans whenever possible for influencing the story! You guys are wonderfully talented and I consider myself incredibly lucky to part of such an active and joyful fandom.
>
> The first shout out I'd like to give is to spacecrier's comic of Entrapta with Robodak that still gives me a lot of feelings. Next is chimkenx's take on how Entrapta got her bug mask (also a three image mini-comic) and a headcanon I 100% agree with. Finally, I'd like to extend an extra huge thank you

to ericamzdm for this tumblr post that basically changed my entire perspective on Entrapta's Beast Island mindset.

No longer I defend / The choices I pretend

Chapter Notes

Happy New Year everyone!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Stars.

There were really stars in the sky.

It was hard to focus on anything else as she climbed the ridge and looked out. Below her, the front gates to the Fright Zone, the quietest she'd ever seen it, and above her, a limitless expanse of possibility. Entrapta would have cried for the sheer joy of it all if it weren't for the dull ache of absence that intruded in on even this moment of wonder. She'd wanted, more than anything, to see the stars, but she'd also always imagined Hordak there with her the first time. She knew she should have been more excited, should have been happier (despite the admittedly serious circumstances of the Heart being activated), but without him, what exuberance she did experience felt a little forced.

Her eyes drifted to the sprawling capital of the Fright Zone, gaze drawn into the direction of Hordak's sanctum. Was he there now? She hoped he was.

At the sound of crunching gravel and shifting sand, Entrapta looked back down where she came from to watch Bow help the birdhorse hobble along.

"See anything?" Bow called up to her as they drew near.

"No." Entrapta replied and jumped down to join them. "Fleetgale feeling any better?"

"Swiftwind," Bow corrected. "And no, not really."

A tail of hair came up to stroke her chin. “Hrm.”

“Look guys,” the horse said weakly. “It’s okay, go on ahead without me.”

Bow frowned and shook his head. “No way, we’re not leaving you behind buddy!”

“It technically *is* an option,” Entrapta said nonchalantly. She pointed a thumb over her shoulder. “The Fright Zone’s practically dead right now so, even with his bright plumage, chances are *very* good that no one would see him out here.”

Bow crossed his arms. “Nuh uh, not happening.”

The horse nosed at the archer. “Bow, you gotta find Glimmer though. Adora's counting on us...”

“But I don’t know where she is or where to even start looking! It could take hours to find her and there's no way we can leave you out here by yourself for that long.”

Entrapta hummed for a moment and lightly thumped a fist into her palm as an idea struck her. “Oh I’ve got it- come here!”

She reached out with her hair and gently grabbed Bow’s shoulders to draw him towards her. Together, she guided him around the edge of the ridge and into full view of the Fright Zone gates.

“Where do you think Glimmer would have been most likely to go?”

“I’m not sure.”

“Gimme your best guess.”

“Uhhh, well, we know Scorpia went with her and they're trying to connect her to her princess powers, so probably wherever the Black Garnet is being kept?”

“Sounds about right.” Entrapta nodded and pointed in the appropriate direction with her hair. “The Garnet chamber is that way, just past that spire with the ledge and lights that kind of looks like a face with its tongue sticking out.”

“The one with the big yellow tubes next to it?”

“Exactly!” She released Bow and smiled at the archer, nodding to the birdhorse as he stepped up to them. “You two go look there.”

“Wait, what? You’re coming with us.”

She shook her head. “No, I’m not.”

“But-”

“Look,” Entrapta interjected sternly. “Quickbreeze-”

“Swiftwind,” the equine grumbled.

“-can’t possibly carry us both right now, right?” She raised a prompting eyebrow to the horse.

“...I could maybe fly with one of you,” he replied with a slight air of hope.

She clapped her hands together. “Then that’s perfect!”

“No it’s-”

“It’s our best lead on where Glimmer might be.” *And it’s definitely* not *where Hordak would likely go.* “You guys check there first. It’ll be faster with just the two of you and if she’s not there, then you can go looking at the prison block nearby.”

“What about you?”

“Me? I’ll go check the places Scorpia would go like the, uh, the barracks!”

He gave her a hesitant look. “...Are you sure you’ll be okay?”

Entrapta couldn't help the little smirk as she put a hand on her hip and waved the other. "Psssh, I'll be fiiine. Bow, trust me. I spent a year and a half combing every square inch of this place- nobody knows it better than me." *Okay, well, maybe one person.* "Besides, we don't have a lot of time and the Fright Zone is a big place. It'll be more efficient if we split up!" *Plus, you guys will just slow me down.*

"Alright, fine." Bow relented. The birdhorse kneeled down to let Bow climb onto his back and straightened unsteadily. "But we meet up back here in an hour, got it?"

"Sure thing!"

"And call if something happens, alright?"

"Yep!"

Bow took one last nervous glance at her as Fastdraft turned and lifted them into the air with a grunt of effort. She half expected them to fall, the way the beast tilted and faltered, but he leveled out and they were gone moments later.

She let out a sigh of relief.

Finally.

Entrapta turned and considered the front gates for a long moment and then screwed a look of determination on her face. With a self assuring nod, she pulled her mask down and set off at a run, vaulting effortlessly over the outer fence. Carried by her hair, she ducked and weaved between pipes, swung past humming engines, and dashed through unusually empty shipping yards, all the while calculating the fastest route to Hordak's lab. She could be there in a matter of minutes if she skipped the sewer detour and used the factory watch tower to swing up and over the recreation building.

She was in her element here, among the tightly woven steel and sprawling industry with its twisting passages and secret pockets of

hidden space. Places built and forgotten, left for her to rediscover and claim all for her own. The crunch of asphalt beneath her boots and the squeak of steel rubbing against her hair, the smell of iron and oil- for the briefest moment she could close her eyes and pretend she'd never left at all.

This was where she belonged.

Pausing only to take a few deep breaths and check her guidelines, Entrapta darted forward and launched herself off the edge of the recreation building, legs kicking out into open air as momentum carried her forward. The weightless feeling of controlled free fall only added to the sensation of giddiness welling up inside her, quickly transforming into bubbling laughter as she landed on the old, weatherworn mattress she knew was waiting for her below on the narrow roof of residential block 8. As she rolled off of it and winded her way down the fire escape, she giggled wickedly and wondered if the mischievous youths who'd secreted the old pallet up there had ever imagined a princess of a neighboring queendom using it as a landing pad.

A sense of elation suffused her every nerve, warming her in a way that had nothing to do with temperature. The grim unease that had followed her from Beast Island was replaced by a steadying confidence and sense of purpose. No matter what happened, in this moment, she was certain everything would be alright. She would find Hordak and they would talk and they'd clear up this whole absurd misunderstanding and if, somehow, it *wasn't* a misunderstanding, she'd shake some sense into that obstinate head of his. Then, after that, they'd put a stop to this whole mess and take a damn nap.

She landed, flushed and panting, just below the exterior vent access to the building that acted as the Fright Zone's palace and dared to smile at it. Yes, she thought as she reached for the grate, they'll work through all of this together just like they always do. The first true flicker of hope that she'd felt in months came to life in her heart as she climbed inside.

Chapter End Notes

Entrapta deserved a bit of a break. ;)

This week's artist shout-out goes to FrightZoneWires! I cannot begin to express how much I adore their art or how helpful it was in visualizing this segment.

Could make amends that heal the loss of precious time

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Her first clue that something was wrong came when she attempted to make the turn that would dump her into the sanctum and was blocked by twisted, partially melted metal. Odd. Brow furrowed but ultimately undeterred, she instead doubled back and took the alternate route to the throne room. Her second clue that something was *very* wrong was the partially collapsed roof and caved in wall that greeted her as she dropped down from the vent to the base of the throne dais.

What had happened here?

Mood dampened by the unexpected display, she looked around cautiously at the empty room, paying particular attention to the long shadows at its edges. She strained her ears for sounds of movement but heard nothing beyond the usual low rumble of the distant reactors that permeated the entire city and the soft creak of aged metal settling and contracting in the rapidly chilling evening air. Warily, she lifted herself up on her hair and stealthily picked her way over clumps of rubble and up the dais. She paused briefly again at the top but when no one came lunging out from the shadows beyond the throne, she continued on down the familiar passages. The acrid smell of burning metal assaulted her nose as she drew closer to the the sanctum and the air felt distinctly warmer in the deserted hallway.

Taking a moment to shake the nervous energy out of her hands, she reached out and opened the door.

The room seemed dimmer than usual and she could feel a distinct sense of wrongness that set her on edge. There was damage to the structure of the room here as well, far beyond the usual

messiness that she expected of their cobbled together workspace. Several of the vitrines had burst, their liquid contents spilled on the floor and their inhabitants sunk to the bottom. She bit her lip and, glancing around and seeing no one, peered apprehensively into the closest fragmented shell of glass at the curled corpse inside. Although Hordak had said none of the would-be clones were viable, she still couldn't help the pang of pity she felt for the poor creature.

Stepping back and taking a deep breath, she looked around more closely at the seemingly abandoned room. Everything was still. She called tentatively out into the darkness but her dry mouth refused to work properly and rendered it instead into an ugly croak. She cleared her throat and tried again.

"Hordak?"

Nothing.

"Imp?"

Silence.

Biting her lip, she stepped further into the sanctum.

The warped remains of their portal machine had been shoved haphazardly against the far wall, the First Ones disc she'd excavated from the Northern Reach leaned against one piece, forgotten and not yet repurposed. A new triptych of screens she didn't recognize sat near Hordak's workstation, one of them covered in a spiderweb of cracks radiating from a small piece of metal that had become lodged in its surface.

Unsurprisingly, Hordak's desk was wiped clean, its contents scattered across the floor amongst the rubble, no doubt during another one of his outbursts. He'd been having fewer and fewer of them in their final few months together, especially after she'd redesigned his exoskeleton; with his pain better managed, she'd really thought they'd been making progress on getting his anger under control. Clearly that problem still remained unresolved.

Entrapta crouched down next to the desk, pulling a crumpled length of paper out from under a pile of broken and disassembled machinery. It was a schematic; one of *her* schematics, no less. Smoothing the paper out on the worktable, she realized it was one she'd been working on before she'd been sent away- an arm cannon she'd been designing for Hordak. It was going to be a surprise, a gift to celebrate the one year anniversary of their successful partnership. Had he found the design and constructed it himself then? Notations in Hordak's script had been made, adjusting several parameters that she quickly realized would significantly increase the power output of the cannon at the sacrifice of safety and an increased risk of overheating and compromising structural integrity.

She glanced over her shoulder; was that what had caused the melted hole several feet to the right of the doorway? Adora *had* mentioned Hordak using some kind of incredibly powerful new weapon in Salineas...

She picked and curled at the edge of the schematic restlessly.

First the pulse bots and now this? But why? Why take such an obvious risk for more power? What was he trying to prove? What did he think he needed all that destructive force anyway? Contrary to popular belief, Hordak wasn't actually interested in destroying or even conquering all of Etheria, just the parts of it that had materials he needed and refused to trade or barter them away. But the portal project had failed, hadn't it? That's why Horde Prime hadn't shown up yet and why Hordak was still here, right? So then why build bigger weapons? Why suddenly push the war harder than it had gone in well over a decade? How could he possibly benefit from that?

Adora said they'd thought she'd been with the Horde the whole time, so clearly her fate had not been public knowledge. Hordak wasn't a cruel man by any stretch, but he *was* a pragmatist; if he'd known she'd been sent to Beast Island, he'd have taunted the Alliance with it or used her exile to distract them in the hopes they do exactly what they did when Scorpia told them. If he'd

developed such a sudden and keen interest in the war, then why hadn't he used that obvious tactic?

Her palms felt sweaty inside her gloves and she flexed them nervously as she looked hard around the empty room once more but, wished as she might, no one was hiding in the lee of a vitrine or caught beneath a pile of scrap. She even sheepishly poked her head inside Hordak's personal quarters, one of his few privacies she'd never invaded, but found the spartan room empty as well.

If Hordak wasn't here, then where was he? Why destroy the lab?

She approached the hole that had been blasted near the door, its edges still glowing red and radiating heat. She rubbed self-consciously at her arms as she surveyed the impromptu passage, noting how it cut into the hallway that led back to the throne room as well as breaking into another hallway beyond it that swerved to her left. With one last look at the empty sanctum, Entrapta carefully followed the wreckage, taking note of the deep scratch marks in the floor at each turn and the variety of blast marks that had seemingly missed their target.

Had Hordak been pursuing someone? Who would he have been fighting while ensconced in the heart of the Fright Zone? There wasn't any residual phosphor magic in the air so it was unlikely to be Glimmer and in all the times she'd seen Scorpia train and fight, she'd never seen the other woman leave scratch marks in anything, just dents.

Entrapta halted at a junction in the path, disrupted by another section of formerly windowed walling that had collapsed and exposed the building to the outside. A gentle wind caressed her hair and curled under her mask, beckoning her as she looked between the unintentional opening and the hallway. She was pretty sure the obvious trail of cannon damage she'd been following continued down the passage in the direction of the Black Garnet chamber and Shadow Weaver's old quarters but tendrils of smoke drifting in through the collapsed wall revealed more fighting had occurred below. Leaning out to peer down at the

source of the smoke, she gasped at the perfectly straight gouge that had been made in the buildings below, pointing directly at the forge and reactors.

What in the world was Hordak thinking? If he'd hit one of the reactors with his canon the resulting chain reaction and residual damage would have crippled the Fright Zone for *months*. She knew he got a bit carried away in his anger, but he was normally so much more methodical and cautious than this!

Biting her lip, Entrapta glanced back at the trail she'd been following. If she continued on to the Garnet chamber, there was a good chance Bow would be there to intercept her. He'd inevitably start asking questions she really wasn't in the mood to answer and she was one hundred percent certain that once he did start asking, she'd never be able to shake him off again to continue her unauthorized search. Clearly she'd need to check there anyway, but if she just so happened to check the forge first, who would be the wiser?

Nodding to herself, Entrapta carefully swung down and landed on the lower building's roof. Just as she was about to make the second drop into the building's exposed hallway, a flash of fluorescent green light made her stagger and pause.

What was that?

Entrapta whirled around, tense and on high alert, but whatever had caused the light was gone just as quickly as it had appeared. She tried her best to ignore the knot of anxiety curling in her stomach and reminded herself she was on a time limit here; Bow had said an hour and it had been what? Twenty minutes already? Thirty?

She grit her teeth and turned her back on the mysterious light.

From the looks of it, Hordak had carved an incredibly direct path through several buildings in his pursuit and it wasn't until she'd hopped across to the third roof that she found a place that had

cooled enough for her to jump down without risking burning herself. Nonetheless, the passage was still uncomfortably hot when she landed and Entrapta protectively pulled her hair in close to her body to prevent it from getting singed.

Thankfully it did not take long for the corridor to reach its terminus and she sighed in relief as she stepped through its archway and into the open expanse of the forge. She was only a scant few steps in, however, before Entrapta halted in her tracks and gasped.

One of the crucible clamps had fallen from its mounting and was precariously balanced on the ledge overlooking the molten iron well. It seemed steady for now, but there was no telling how long it would be before the surface below the several ton piece gave way. Entrapta nervously eyed the remaining equipment hanging from the ceiling as well as the wreckage surrounding her; had any of the others sustained enough damage to come loose from their mooring?

"Hello?" Entrapta called out.

Nothing, again, just the low rumble and viscous bubble of liquid metal below.

How in the world could she possibly be the only one here? The forge was a complete disaster and should have warranted a priority emergency response. Sure, the Fright Zone was in the middle of an offensive, but Hordak *always* left a portion of the populace at home to hold the fort and ensure things continued to run smoothly. So where was Adamantia and her team? Technically everyone in this section of the Fright Zone was military trained and could fight if the need arose, but it made absolutely no sense to send out the Forgemistress when she could be here, crafting and plying her trade.

Entrapta took a few steps forward, head craned up and swiveling wildly as she gawked; Adamantia was going to be utterly *furious* when she saw this. A crunch at her feet gave her pause and she

raised her boot to look at the cracked plastic beneath it. It belonged to a larger pile of smashed pieces intermixed with deformed metal and the shattered remains of a red, glass-like substance. She picked at the pieces with her hair, bringing a few up to examine closer, but it wasn't until she moved the third curved piece to reveal a length of severed tubing that she realized what it was.

Hordak's cannon.

So it had broken after all. But how? Even if he *had* overclocked the machine, it would have been more likely to burn him or warp and fry its own components than splinter like this. Assuming Hordak had finally caught up to his opponent and they'd fought, it was still hard to imagine that someone else had done this; something like that would require an impressive amount of force behind a well placed strike. A lucky hit then? She could think of no other way for the cannon to end up in its current state and there was, thankfully, no viscera around to suggest an implosion.

"Hordak?" Entrapta called again, louder.

She abandoned the remains of the cannon and paced delicately around, examining everything and occasionally lifting herself as high as she could on her hair to better see the area. This was obviously the end of Hordak's demolition trail but, unless he was under the clamp *(please please please no)*, she couldn't see where he'd gone or what had become of his adversary. There were thick gouges in the ground near the clamp's edge, spaced oddly, as if something had dug in for purchase, but nothing to suggest-

What was that?

A small object glittering a dull, dark magenta in the red and orange light of the room lay a few feet away from the clamp. It was butted up against and partially obscured by dislodged pieces of masonry so she'd missed it on her first few turns about the

room. She took a hesitant step forward, her hand unconsciously reaching out towards the little diamond.

It couldn’t be, could it?

Chapter End Notes

> Idk if Adamantia will ever actually show up "on screen" or not, but I like to think she's the same species as Grox and Grizzlor. :)
> --
> Today's artist shout-out goes to fattyaly!

My conscience paralyzed / Against the rising tide

Chapter Notes

> Gotta say, you guys talking so much about Entrapta on tumblr this last weekend has been, *chef kiss* mwah, very useful as I work on the season 5 stuff. ;)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Entrapta approached the shimmering shard almost in a daze but as she crouched to pick it up a black and blue blur leapt out from above her and landed on it, aiming a vicious hiss in her direction. She yelped and fell back onto her butt while the creature snatched the object and fled. It perched on the edge of the clamp and turned to screech at her once more, its yellow eyes narrowed to angry slits.

"Son of a-" Her growl melted into a gasp as she looked up. "*Imp*? Is that you?"

The yellow eyes widened in surprise and the creature shrank back a little. Entrapta bounced to her feet and pulled up her mask, smiling broadly up at her friend.

"It's me!"

"[Entrapta.]" Imp replied in Hordak's voice, making her heart skip a beat. The little creature screeched wildly and dive bombed into her open arms, knocking the breath out of her and causing her to stumble back a few steps. She recovered quickly however and immediately wrapped her arms and hair around Imp in a tight embrace.

"Ooooh," she cooed, hardly able to keep still as she curled around him and spun back and forth in a half circle. "Oh, my little Imp! I've missed you so much!" She could feel tears welling up in the

corners of her eyes and he chattered in her ear and nuzzled his face against the side of her own. “I’m so happy to see you!”

Entrapta nuzzled him back and brought a hand up to cradle his head, her face hurting from the sheer force of her smile. Imp’s own vocalizations soon died down, however, and he stared up at her with an expression of pure disbelief.

“What’s wrong?”

“[How] [did you get] [here?]” Imp relied in a jumble of mismatched voices she didn’t recognize.

Her brow knit in confusion. “What?”

“[Dead…]” he repeated, this voice softer and more agonized. He touched her cheek softly with one hand, raised the other, still clenching tightly to the object he’d grabbed from the floor, to his own chest, and let out a pitiable whine.

“Y-you thought I was…?”

Imp nodded solemnly and nuzzled her again, his small arms wrapping around her neck and his tail curling around her arm. She hummed reassuringly back at him and pulled him closer, gently kissing his hair.

“I’m so glad you’re okay,” she whispered after a long moment. Imp pulled back and looked up at her, a mixture of surprise and something else on his face. She looked away and chewed at the inside of her cheek, almost afraid to ask but knowing that she needed to.

“Does...does Hordak think-”

Imp gasped and screeched loudly, his sudden flailing startling her badly enough she nearly dropped him.

“Woah! Hey, it’s okay!” Imp did not heed her however, and continued to gesticulate wildly, his yellow eyes wide in panic.

“Hey, hey, heeey, it’s alright! Everything will be okay,” she soothed, touching her forehead to his. “We’ll figure this out. But first,” she gestured to the room with one of her shorter locks of hair. “I need you to tell me as best you can what happened here.”

Imp frowned and looked down at her collar for a long moment, seeming lost in thought. When he looked up at her again, he opened his mouth and another voice she did not recognize came spilling out.

“[Ugh. I know, I know. No one is welcome in Hordak’s super-secret sanctum. Not since you let that princess in.]” Imp paused, thought for a moment, and continued. “[No small talk? I thought I’d at least get a pat on the back for my daring escape. It’s too bad, though. I was looking forward to meeting this Entrapta character before I left Brightmoon.]”

Entrapta frowned. “Is that...what was their name? Adora mentioned it...That's the shape shifter who joined the Horde and infiltrated Brightmoon?”

Imp nodded vigorously and opened his mouth again. “[But of course, as you know, she wasn’t there.]”

“[What did you say?]” cut in Hordak’s voice.

“[Oh you don’t need to keep up the charade with me,]” continued the shape shifter. “[I figured out the truth. You had Catra send Entrapta to Beast Island, so She-Ra would run off to rescue her. A brillian-]”

“N-no, he-” Entrapta gasped. Imp scowled and shook his head, pointing at his ear and then at her. She flushed. “R-right, sorry. Continue.”

“[-erfect distraction. I have to applaud your work, you really had me going. So *scorned* by Entrapta’s *betrayal*. Even now you look like you had no idea!]”

There was a brief pause after the shifter’s far-too-amused words and a soft growl from Hordak.

“[Brava. I mean, I did consider the alternative, that Catra’s been lying to you this whole time. That she made you think she was your partner in crime, while really she is the one who betrayed you.]”

Imp cut the recording off as the shifter started laughing and Entrapta stared at him in shock.

“C-Catra told you guys I- you know I would *never* do something like-"

Entrapta sputtered for a moment, breathing heavily as a million thoughts and feelings came crashing down on her at once. Outrage, however, won out.

"And Hordak *believed* her!? ” she shrilly half shouted.

“[-that idiot!]” Imp threw his tiny hands up in disgust and nodded in agreement.

She chewed at her lip and glanced away. “...what did Hordak do after that?”

Imp’s expression saddened and he rubbed at his eyes with his empty hand, making a big show of sniffing and breathing badly.

“He..." Entrapta squinted for a moment, gasping as Imp's mimicry clicked. "No way. Hordak doesn’t- he’s never-” Imp continued to mime tears running down his chubby cheeks and made little chirping sounds that reminded her of quiet sobs. “He thought I was dead and he...cried. He really, actually cried? For *me*?”

Imp nodded and pointed at himself.

"And...you did too."

He nuzzled her cheek once more before pulling back and opening his mouth again.

"[There. The traitor is on her way.]" Hordak's voice was harsh and straining under barely confined anger. There was a quiet moment as he took several deep, shuddering breaths and when he spoke next, his voice was surprisingly soft and raw. "[Go.]" Imp mimed a hand coming down to pat his head and stroked his own cheek. "[I do not wish to catch you in the crossfire.]"

"He didn't want you to get hurt," she whispered.

Imp nodded solemnly.

"But you followed him anyway, didn't you?"

Imp puffed his chest out and schooled his features into one of dutiful determination, nodding once more.

Entrapta smiled back at him and let out a little huff of amusement. "Yeah, I'd have done the same thing."

Imp looked up at her, carefully studying her features and clearly lost in thought. Before she could ask him what he was thinking about, he looked down at the pinkish object poking out his closed fist and then back up at her. Whatever he was looking for, she must have passed muster, because Imp slowly uncurled his fingers for her to see.

The sinking dread she'd been feeling coalesced into a hard lump in her stomach.

"Hordak's power crystal…"

Sparing it one last tentative glance, Imp held the crystal out for her and she took it reverently. She turned the small diamond in her hand several times, relieved to find it undamaged.

"Catra must have yanked it out during their fight…" she breathed. Imp glowered and nodded.

Her throat felt tight and she had to swallow a few times in order to continue.

"Imp?"

He chirped softly.

"Did Hordak *really* believe I'd betrayed you guys and gone to the Alliance?"

Imp thought for a long moment before he spoke.

"[Besides, out of all the princesses, Entrapta has yet to face me on the field.]"

She grimaced. "I see."

As Entrapta looked around the room, the hard mass in her stomach came alive, curling and roiling into something bitter and vicious.

It made sense now; Hordak had intensified the war looking for her. That was why her credentials hadn't been purged from the Fright Zone's security system despite her supposed betrayal- he'd *wanted* her to come back and face him and when she never showed, he'd taken to the battlefield to look for himself. The pulse bots- the cannon- all of it a taunt, a direct challenge meant to push her into action. He'd probably wanted to drive her out of hiding, to hunt her down and get revenge for hurting him.

So much destruction and pain and hate all because Catra had lied, *again*. Hordak had waged a war, destroyed his sanctum and a healthy swathe of the Fright Zone, and grieved for her all because of a horrid misunderstanding. And how many times had she felt the urge to give in to the signal back on Beast Island? She'd nearly let go of Hordak and had almost managed to actually convince herself that he'd used her. She'd genuinely started to believe that she was a lost cause, an unlovable and unwanted burden on others, all because of *Catra*.

Her jaw hurt from how hard she clenched her teeth.

It wasn't fair. None of this was fair.

She'd tried so many times to be sympathetic to the Catra, tried to forgive her callousness and explain away her cruelty, but how much more did the feline need to take from them all before she was satisfied? How many more lives did she need to ruin before it was enough?

Imp chirped at her in concern and pressed down gently on her bad shoulder. She hissed sharply at the stinging pain and he wrenched his hand back in alarm, looking frantically between her face and shoulder.

"Sorry, sorry, ah, no, no, it's okay," she winced. "I'm okay."

Imp squinted at her for a long moment. "[Liar.]"

"No, really, I am! It's just a light injury, nothing super serious."

"[Liar.]" he repeated.

She blinked at him a few times. "Heh, I guess you're used to calling Hordak out about this kind of thing, aren't you?"

Imp nodded.

"Well, I *promise* I'll be okay and I promise I'll have someone look at it just as soon as we get things figured out here, yeah?"

He pouted at her and she ruffled his hair with a lock of her own, earning an annoyed screech.

Entrapta's eyes drifted to the broken arm cannon a few feet away and the massive passageway Hordak had carved into the forge. She chewed at her cheek and thumbed the edge of Hordak's crystal.

Righteous fury mingled with the biting anguish curling in her stomach, its acrid taste threatening to bubble back up and choke her. There was an almost paralyzing nature to the feeling, a fear of what she might learn counterbalanced by a desperate need to find Hordak. Worst of all was the dark desire underscoring everything, a chanting softly in the back of her mind, insisting she abandon everything, find Catra, and *make her pay*. It was sickening and she dreaded that she might never find Hordak, that he might never know that she was alive and that she'd been looking for him.

No, there was still time.

It wasn't too late- they could still fix things. She could still ask him to stay with her, directly this time- no allusions or thinly veiled excuses. Even if he said no, even if he did still leave, at the very least they could do it properly this time.

"Imp," she said softly, blinking the blurriness from her eyes. "Do you know where Hordak is?"

He nodded sharply and jumped from her arms, hopping several feet away towards the forge entrance. He paused and turned back to look at her, beckoning her with the wave of a hand. She nodded and immediately followed.

Imp seemed to be leading her more or less back the way she'd come, although he opted to take them on a slightly less direct route rather than Hordak's original forced path. They zigzagged in and around the buildings, Imp pausing occasionally for her to catch up or open doors for them, but it wasn't until the third flight of stairs that Entrapta realized she was back in the hallway just outside the Garnet chamber. Imp hopped onto her shoulder and she immediately brought a pony tail up to support his weight; he squeaked softly and pointed to the chamber door.

"Here? Really?"

Imp nodded and she hummed, clenching and unclenching her hands nervously a few times before reaching out to the door's keypad. The door slid open smoothly but as she stepped inside she saw the door itself was honestly a wasted formality compared to the rest of the room.

The ceiling and the vast majority of the chamber's walls were gone, much of the missing material in crumbled piles along the room's perimeter. The Garnet itself was still standing and seemed unharmed, but directly next to it a large, near perfect circle had been cut into the floor. To her begrudging relief, there was no sign of Bow but a bit of Glimmer's signature phosphor glow still hung in the air near the Garnet, suggesting she'd been there recently.

Entrapta tentatively stepped up to the hole's edge and peered down at the exposed room below. Just like every place else in the Fright Zone, it was deserted. However, the room was oddly clean and untouched with no sign of damage or any trace of the Garnet chamber's chunk of missing flooring.

She furrowed her brow and looked at Imp.

"What in the world happened here?"

Imp hopped down and stood near the hole's edge as well, pointing at it and opening his mouth.

"[Horde Prime, he's here.]"

The voice clip was muffled and a bit distant, but it was unmistakably Hordak's voice, tired and almost desperate yet tinged with an air of smug triumph.

"I don't understand."

Imp took his fist and mimed it rising up from the hole, opening it as it rose higher and fluttering it away in the air above him with little wooshy mouth noises. Finally he pointed directly up at the sky and repeated "[Horde Prime]" once more.

Her mouth dropped open and she gawked at Imp, looking from him to the sky. At some point during her investigation the wide, beautiful expanse of stars had been blotted out by a fleet of what could only be star ships. She'd been so focused on following Hordak's trail, she hadn't even noticed their dark silhouettes gliding above them.

"The green flash…" she whispered.

The Galactic Horde had gotten Hordak's message after all and she'd missed him.

She'd chosen the wrong direction and now Hordak was gone.

Chapter End Notes

I hope the brackets around Imp's speech both make sense and aren't too distracting. There's no smooth way to indicate how he swaps between voice clips in written text and this was a method I'd seen other writers use that I liked. I'm unsure if it meshes badly with text to audio readers though, so if it becomes an issue, let me know and I can make some adjustments!

Similarly, I feel like it's worth mentioning that I'm definitely not a Catra anti by any means, but there's no denying this story is pretty harsh on her. It's kind of one of those things where when one of her victims starts properly tallying up the score, no matter how forgiving you want to be, Catra's got a lot to answer for and Entrapta has a lot to be pissed off and upset about. I promise Catra will get her chance to prove herself in this series (I'm a strong proponent of Hordak and her being the worst best friends who totally hate one another but also are the *only* ones allowed to hate each other) but this part is not that time.

Btw, if anyone is looking for some good Entrapdak music suggestions or is curious about the music I listen to when writing this, check out the thread entrapdaknation has started

over on tumblr and maybe even add some suggestions of your own!

Of haunting memories that drown a wasted life

Chapter Notes

> I want to toss a quick honorable mention to Dae! Her art is always so lovely and I went positively wild when she posted this the day after I released the first chapter of Electric Tapestry. Neither of us had any influence on one another, but I just love the picture so much and it really captures a lot of the exact same feelings I've been aiming for here. Thanks for the food Dae!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"B-but- no- that's not…"

Entrapta brought a hand to her temple and swayed a little. It was getting hard to breathe and she felt dizzy all of a sudden.

"H-he *can't* be-"

Imp reached out for her, sharing her pained expression, and seemed about to say something but was interrupted by a muffled voice from behind them.

"-have secured the Garnet then we can-"

The chamber door hissed open once more and someone gasped, their footsteps halting sharply followed by the sound of an ungraceful "oomph!" coming a half second later.

"Princess!"

Entrapta turned vacantly towards the new arrival. A broad, blue furred man stood in the doorway, his usual yellow eyed sternness disrupted by surprise. He held a tablet in one hand, a matching earpiece wrapped around one pointed ear, while his free hand hovered over the door panel.

“Commander Cobalt,” she greeted blankly.

“P-princess!?” squeaked a voice behind the soldier, a blond head poking into view.

“Oh, and Kyle, too.”

“Oh my gosh!” Kyle’s hands shot up to his mouth, the edge of his own tablet clipping him in the forehead. “Ow.”

Cobalt ignored him, his startled expression darkening a moment later. The taciturn commander’s free hand hesitantly came to rest on the stun baton at his waist as he studied her carefully.

“What are you doing here, your highness?”

She smiled bitterly. “Looking for Hordak.”

Cobalt’s frown deepened. “But you were the one who let the-”

Imp screeched and flew between them, his wings flapping wildly as he stared Cobalt down.

“[Catra’s been lying to you this whole time,]” came the shape shifter’s voice.

“Wait, isn’t that-” Kyle squeaked.

“Catra’s informant, Double Trouble.” Cobalt finished.

Oh, so that was their name. Double Trouble. Hm, it sounded like it suited them.

Imp nodded. “[-Catra send Entrapta to Beast Island-]”

“She *what* ?” Cobalt took a half step back, gaze rapidly darting between Imp and Entrapta.

Entrapta shrugged.

"But she was the one who brought you on- I thought you were friends?"

"Actually sir," Kyle scowled. "I'm not so sure that'd make much difference with Catra."

Cobalt opened his mouth to reply but came up empty. He glowered and looked back to Entrapta.

"Catra pushes for results and you've only ever been an asset, so why would she suddenly turn on you like that?"

An asset, huh? Well, at least she'd done one thing right in the past year and a half.

“I realized the portal was too dangerous to use and would potentially kill us all, so I tried to warn Hordak but Catra didn’t like that so she-” Entrapta took a shallow breath, curling her fingers tightly. The hard edges of Hordak’s crystal through her gloves was oddly nice, centering even. “...attacked me. Then the portal was opened and the alternate reality and then, next thing I knew, I was waking up on Beast Island.”

As the silence dragged on, she looked away from Cobalt’s wide eyed gaze.

“Wow,” Kyle scoffed. “No wonder Catra's been so jumpy. She's been so mean lately, Lonnie and Rogelio were sure something was up, but that’s low, even for her.”

Everyone stared at the cadet.

“What?” Kyle cried, arms flailing for emphasis under Cobalt’s scowl. “It’s true!”

Entrapta huffed lightly in wry amusement. “Yeah, it is. I should have expected it, but I didn’t.”

Imp flew back to Entrapta and she took him into her arms once more. Cobalt hummed but didn’t clear the doorway or take his

hand off his stun baton.

“Forgive my suspicion, your highness, but *how*, exactly, did you get back from the unsurvivable island?”

Dumb luck and the goodwill of some naive kids who want me to help them kill you all, even if they don’t realize that’s what they’re asking for yet?

She held back a derisive snort and chose a more diplomatic approach.

“Scorpia knew- she was there when Catra sent me to Beast Island.”

Cobalt’s face scrunched into a disbelieving squint. “...Princess Scorpia.”

“Mhm.”

“*Our* Scorpia.”

“Yup.”

“The young woman who is loyal and honest to a fault?"

"Mhm."

"The Force Captain who famously turned herself in for letting another student copy her homework and cried because she felt guilty?”

At another time, Entrapta might have laughed at that.

“Same person. She went to the Princess Alliance for help a day or two ago.”

Cobalt’s jaw dropped.

“Ooooh,” Kyle exclaimed, head tilting back in thought. “That would explain why she was with the Brightmoon Queen.”

Cobalt's head whipped around so fast Entrapta half worried he'd pull something.

"She *what?* " he hissed. "You- wait- *when did you see the Queen?* "

Kyle shrank back a little. "Just before Lonnie, Rogelio, and I ran into you?"

Cobalt advanced a step towards Kyle and growled. "And you didn't think this was important enough information to share sooner!?"

Kyle snapped at attention and saluted. "Sorry sir! Scorpia said she was here to help, sir!"

"I-" Cobalt sighed and scrubbed at his face. "Fine. Who *else* is here? We have to get this damn counter invasion under contro-"

"There is no counter invasion." Entrapta cut in, matter of fact.

"Excuse me?" He turned back to Entrapta, defensive stance and stun baton long forgotten. "Then who's setting off explosions across the Fright Zone?"

"Hordak."

"...what."

They both ignored Kyle's low "wooooah."

"Double Trouble told him about Catra; that's why Imp has those recordings."

The little clone nodded fervently in her arms.

"Why would they do that? They worked directly under Catra- outside the rank and file."

"I dunno," she shrugged with her hair. "But according to Imp, after they left Hordak had some kind of stand off with Catra. I'm

not entirely sure what happened but Hordak's cannon is in pieces down in the forge."

"And...he's not?"

"No. Imp says he came here."

"And Catra?"

They all looked to Imp who shrugged.

Kyle's data pad beeped a moment later, breaking the silence.

"Oh! Sir! I have confirmation from Lonnie that the Whispering Woods squadron has reestablished communications."

Cobalt hummed and slowly turned to Kyle.

"And their status?"

"They suffered some pretty significant equipment damage and they've been kind of badly scattered, but, thankfully, they're reporting minimal injuries so far."

"And General Grizzlor?"

"Um...there's mention that he's with one of the groups split from the main force but nothing on their condition."

Cobalt nodded. "Any luck reaching Admiral Octavia and her fleet yet?"

"No sir, but Rogelio's messaged saying he's completed his sweep of the barracks and made contact with medbay and the infirmary."

"Any casualties?"

Kyle tapped at his screen and smiled a moment later. "Other than a few of the younger kids being startled by the explosions, everyone's safe and accounted for. The kitchen and civilian staff

followed the standard evacuation orders and are also sheltered there with the medical staff and caretakers."

Cobalt's eyes closed briefly and his shoulders relaxed a fraction. "Good. And Force Captain Antonia?"

"Still no update from her directly but Lonnie copied over her last check-in a few minutes ago. Aside from a couple stray cadets, they haven't found anything."

Cobalt looked at Entrapta and Imp for a long moment, his hard gaze making her itch and reminding Entrapta of one of her many childhood governesses. He nodded to himself and, consulting his tablet, turned to Kyle once more.

"Alright, new orders."

Kyle nodded and studiously began taking notes.

"Alert all hands we are not under attack but to remain vigilant- there may still be Brightmoon agents on the premises." Cobalt looked to Entrapta. "Should I be concerned about the individuals who I assume accompanied you here?"

Entrapta shook her head. "They won't pick a fight unless someone comes at them first- they just want to get Glimmer and Scorpia and leave."

Cobalt grimaced but turned back to Kyle.

"If anyone encounters enemy combatants, they are *not* to engage."

"We're letting them go, sir?"

"Did I stutter?"

"N-no sir!"

“Force Captain Antonia and her team are to abandon the perimeter check and join Rogelio and the civilians at the infirmary blast shelter. Tell them to rest and await further orders.”

“Yes sir.”

“The Black Garnet is secure and under no threat. Force Captain Lonnie is to continue to attempt to raise Admiral Octavia and her forces. If either the Admiral or General Grizzlor report in, have them contact me personally; they’ll know how.”

“Got it.”

“Finally,” Cobalt glanced again at Entrapta and Imp. “Alert all hands that Catra is a rogue agent. Any and all orders from her are null and, if encountered, she is to be detained for questioning under the order of Lord Hordak.”

Kyle looked up hesitantly. “S-sir?”

“I have never known you to be a liar, your highness,” Cobalt said to Entrapta. “Nor do I have any reason to doubt the Fright Zone’s most skilled spy and Lord Hordak’s most trusted companion.” He dipped his head in respect to Imp. “I hope my faith in you both is not misplaced.”

Entrapta blinked a few times at him. The corner of her mouth quirked up sourly and she pointed at her back with a tail of hair. “I’ve got the scars to prove it, if you really need it.”

“That will be unnecessary.” He turned back to Kyle. “Catra is to be considered a level 1 priority target and approached with extreme caution. If she attempts to make contact or her badge tracker pings, I want to know about it *immediately*.”

“Yes sir.” Kyle saluted.

“Go. Return when you have finished.”

Kyle nodded and affixed a communicator to his ear as he scurried out of the room, the door swishing closed behind him.

Chapter End Notes

Antonia is the name I gave to the rad lizard lady you see sitting with Scorpia and Adora at the Force Captains meeting during s3e5, "Remember"; she deserved one. :)

I'm running with the headcanon that, because Catra mobilized nearly every able body at the end of season 4, the only people who remained behind were the absolute *minimum* required. This equates to a bunch of cadets with unfinished training, soldiers like the Horde Trio who are still transitioning to their permanent placements, a Force Captain or two, and Cobalt who's entire job is to oversee "affairs at home" and essentially *never* leaves the Fright Zone. Basically, in the hierarchy, Cobalt's a half step below Shadow Weaver/Catra and looks after the things Hordak's 2nd doesn't.

Edit 4/15/21: For anyone curious, I wrote out my headcanon on how the Fright Zone's military ranking system works. It's not a necessary detail, but if that sounds appealing to you, check it out here!

A broken mirror only shows as best it can

Chapter Notes

> While I was editing this chapter and prepping it for posting, I realized there are a few more gut punches in here than I'd remembered. So heeey, gonna just toss in a little bit of a religious guilt/cult indoctrination content warning in here, just in case. It's, ah, well, I mean, it's Horde Prime so I suspect you guys have an idea of what to expect, but, y'know, maybe grab a cup of tea or something first.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Cobalt closed his eyes and pinched the bridge of his stubby nose. He sighed and suddenly seemed a great deal older and more tired to Entrapta; Imp looked up at her, eyebrow arched in apparent agreement.

“Hordak’s gone, isn’t he?”

“Yes,” she replied softly.

“Is he…?”

“Dead?” By whatever power existed in the universe, she hoped not. “No. Imp says he’s with Horde Prime.”

“Horde...Prime.” Cobalt’s frown deepened and he looked up at her more clearly, pointing to the ships moving above them. “Then that means *they’re* the Galactic Horde.”

“We think so.”

Cobalt cursed softly and ran a hand through the longer fur on his head. Entrapta honestly did not envy his position- the Horde scattered across a significant portion of Etheria, the Fright Zone severely damaged and its resources depleted, Brightmoon rebels inside the city, both Catra and Double Trouble marked as traitors,

their leader missing without any indication of how long or where, and all while their supposed parent army floated over their heads with no way to anticipate how they'd be received.

"How much did Hordak tell you?" He finally asked.

Entrapta thought back to that evening in the sanctum when Hordak had fainted, of how he'd spoken of Horde Prime and his people, and the myriad of shorter, smaller details he'd let slip as they'd grown even more comfortable around one another, as he'd relaxed and let her see more of his private life.

"Enough to make me nervous."

Imp frowned and nodded as well.

"You?" she prompted.

Cobalt shook his head. "It's less what he told me directly and more that I remember how he used to talk about him in the early days."

Entrapta tilted her head. "Early days?"

"When we still worked for the King."

"I didn't realize you guys have known each other so long."

Cobalt nodded. "Hordak had already been here for a bit by the time Grizz and I joined, but he was still quite a bit different back then."

"How so?"

"He was more...open, less distrustful. Still quiet and overly serious, but eager to please and a bit naive and idealistic for a soldier."

"That's sort of hard to imagine."

"It's been nearly thirty years, a lot's happened since then."

“What kinds of things did he used to say about the Horde?”

Cobalt hummed for a moment. “The way Hordak talked about his people, the little rituals and prayers he’d do when he thought he was alone- all of it was eerily similar to the Artificers.”

Oh.

He frowned, studying her for a moment. “You were probably a bit young for that, so I’m not sure if you’ll remember...”

She curled the ends of her hair and chewed at her cheek.

Religion wasn’t a particularly common thing on Etheria, certainly not unheard of, but most of it was loose and localized, often taking the form of animism or centered around the runestones or similar magic sources like the moons. Historical texts suggested this had not always been the case and that, especially during periods closer to the time of the First Ones, religion had been both more common and more organized. However, when the First Ones disappeared, they took the bulk of that part of their culture with them and Etheria generally moved on.

The Order of the First Artificers, however, had different ideas. What had started out as a collective of passionate Drylian researchers, dedicated to learning about the lost culture of the First Ones and Etheria’s forgotten past, morphed into an obsessive group of people who worshiped the First Ones as the true masters of Etheria and the Princesses as their direct descendants.

They’d been easy enough to tolerate at first and, as far as she was aware, her parents had for the bulk of their reign. However, as time passed, the group started expanding, targeting young and vulnerable individuals and taking advantage of global unrest and a rise in poverty. They grew bolder after her parent's deaths, either because of or without regard to, she didn't know, and began insisting that the various queendoms adopt the Order as their official state religion. Before long, they’d set off a small scale uprising across much of Etheria, actively attacking other faiths,

threatening the faithless, attempting to dethrone royalty deemed ‘impure’ or ‘unworthy’ of their noble blood, and indirectly speeding up the formation of Brightmoon’s first Princess Alliance.

It was a dark stain on Dryl’s history but, as her ministers and advisors had told her time and again, no one had been prepared to deal with it, let alone an uncoronated 15 year old Princess of the Lesser Court.

“I remember,” she intoned.

Cobalt nodded and looked up at the fleet above them. “Hordak would go on and on about the ‘Light of Prime’ and how Prime was some kind of savior of the universe and Hordak and his people were all part of this grand, divine mission to bring peace to all creation...or something like that.”

“That’s...a lot.”

“None of us took it very seriously at the time. It didn’t exactly inspire confidence, but King Scorpio took it all in good humor and, for all of his eccentricities, Hordak always came through for us, so it was easy enough to shrug off.”

“I wonder why he never mentioned any of this…”

“That might be because of us." Cobalt huffed in amusement, corner of his lip quirking up. "He used to get so furious with us whenever we were a little too glib about the whole thing. It's possible we went a bit far with our teasing though- by the time the Queens were in power and Octavia had defected from Salineas, he'd stopped trying to covert us altogether."

"He tried to *convert* you?"

"Grizzlor would probably argue it was more of a threat."

"What?"

"Hordak swore to us that Prime would come for us all eventually and we'd be better off going to him willingly than incurring his wrath."

"Ominous."

"Yeah." Cobalt's brow creased. "He hasn't talked about any of them since he took stewardship of the throne. I thought he'd given all that nonsense up *years* ago."

She felt a tug at her hair and looked down to see Imp's head bowed, his fingers clenching and twining in the strands. His shoulders were tense and he'd pulled his wings and tail in tightly; what little she could see of his face seemed apprehensive. Entrapta hummed softly and gently stroked the back of Imp's head with a strand of hair, her arms curling a little tighter around his small body in a way she hoped he found reassuring.

"You okay?"

Imp's hands twisted deeper into her hair.

"You don't trust Prime, do you?" she asked Imp softly.

Imp didn't respond. To her, he seemed to be at war with himself, struggling to determine what was safe to share and what would be a betrayal of Hordak's privacy. Not for the first time, Entrapta wished they had a better form of communication than whatever limited collection of voice clips Imp had saved to mimic with, but even if he did figure out what to say, there was no guarantee he'd be able to share.

Imp was indeed locked in an intense inner struggle, but not over secrets and privacies. Imp already knew in his heart that Entrapta was good. She was safe- safer than Brother likely realized- and she belonged in their family even if Brother was too stupid to understand that yet. And Cobalt? Brother trusted Cobalt, even if he never said so, and Imp knew from his own experience that Cobalt was dependable in an emergency too large and heavy for Imp's tiny form. Cobalt already knew things nobody else knew and

suspected things Imp and Brother would *never* confirm- things that only Entrapta knew. Cobalt had also helped Imp many times with things that were dangerous and Forbidden To Speak Of And Must Be Hidden but that was okay because, most of all, Cobalt knew how to be discrete and keep his damn mouth shut. No, it wasn't a matter of trust Imp wrestled with, but a crisis of faith.

The problem was both Cobalt and Entrapta were suggesting the Maker was bad, but how could the Maker be bad? It would be one thing if just Cobalt was saying that- Cobalt didn't know better so he couldn't be blamed, but Entrapta too? Brother had told her about the Maker so she should know not to say upsetting things like that. Brother would be mad if he knew- he *loved* the Maker and spoke reverently of Him and shared His teachings with Imp. Brother said the Maker was right and just and good and that they should do everything they could to be like the Maker so that one day they could return to the Maker and be happy.

Except...Imp was *already* happy in the Fright Zone- he did not want to leave his home and go to the Maker's Throne and serve Him; he wanted to stay right here and continue to be Brother's Little Spy and pick on the cadets and steal snacks and assist Entrapta and play with Emily. Imp was good at all of those things and liked it here, but Brother said their place was with the Maker and it's what He wants that's important and the Maker is *always* right, even if they don't understand why or how.

Except...the Maker had said Brother was Unworthy and Defective while Entrapta said Brother was Unique and Special. Brother said pain was a gift from the Maker, designed to test their faith and make them stronger, but Imp did not like to feel pain and did not think Brother needed to suffer in order to be powerful and brave. Brother was already more than brave and plenty capable, even if sometimes he wasn't strong enough to lift Imp on his own.

Brother also said the Maker was always watching over them and heard their prayers but no matter how much they asked the Maker for help, He never came. Imp had asked the Maker to heal Brother hundreds- thousands of times, at *least*, but Brother only

kept getting sicker and sicker and it was always up to Imp to watch over Brother and get him water and medicine and lock the door so nobody would See. In fact, nothing had happened so many times, he'd given up on asking the Maker for help entirely and simply resolved to take care of Brother himself because if they kept waiting for the Maker, Brother would die.

But Entrapta was different; she showed them a better way to live and didn't ask them to kneel or repent or tithe. When she'd found out that Brother was sick she didn't shun him as Worthless like the Maker did- she was kind and gentle and helped Imp care for Brother and when Brother had woken up, she's *kept* helping and made the pain less bad. She made Brother smile all the time, especially when he didn't think anyone was looking, and, unlike the silent Maker, she said and did all kinds of nice things for Brother that actually made a difference.

All of these things meant the Maker had to be wrong, but the Maker could *never* be wrong so that meant...*Entrapta* had to be lying, right? But Entrapta isn't a liar, so that meant...what? Maybe...maybe Brother was wrong? Brother was very smart, but he made mistakes and was wrong about things sometimes but that was okay because nobody but the Maker was truly perfect. So...could Brother be wrong about that too? Imp really did not mind if he was- the Maker sounded mean and unpleasant and although Brother said the Maker would be very impressed with Imp and would of course find a place for him within his Kingdom of Light, Imp was still skeptical.

Imp had never met Him and was not entirely sure he believed in the Maker's goodness, but he did believe in Brother and loved Brother as his Creator, so he understood why Brother still loved the Maker despite His flaws. However, when all was said and done, it didn't really matter all that much what Imp believed because it was what Brother believed and he had faith in Brother to do was what right for the both of them, just like he always did.

After all, brothers look after one another (*No matter what!*) so there was no way Brother would have worked so hard to reunite

them with the Maker if the Maker was dangerous.

Except...Brother was gone and Imp was left behind and nothing was going the way Brother had said it would and now Entrapta was here and Brother had been wrong about that too and he was *scared*.

"Imp?" Entrapta called to him softly.

Even if Imp had been capable of a more fully formed version of speech or had access to a writing implement or if Entrapta knew Horde Sign, it wouldn't have mattered. Memories of Hordak and things they'd never had reason to question before Entrapta had shown up in their lives intermingled with feelings of fear and doubt and everything Imp thought he knew as fact suddenly felt terribly wrong. Even if he'd been able to express what he thought or felt to Entrapta in this moment, he wouldn't have had a clue where to begin and it was precisely because of this frustration that Imp pulled away from Entrapta, flying up to rest on top of the Black Garnet with his back to both her and Cobalt.

"Hey, what's wrong?" Entrapta asked worriedly. When he did not respond she raised herself up on her hair and sent a tendril reaching up towards him. Before she could touch him however, her pocket began ringing.

"Shit."

With an impatient groan and a last look at Imp, she lowered herself back down to her feet and fished the data pad from her overalls. It was an older model, a spare that Bow had given to her just before they'd left Brightmoon. She hadn't even really had time to properly configure it or mess with the settings, let alone soup it up with her preferred modifications and expansions, but apparently it worked well enough as a communicator because, yes, Bow was calling her.

Damn it all- she was out of time.

She grimaced at Cobalt as the pad rang again. “Sorry, if I don’t take this...”

He graciously swept a hand in her direction. “Pretend I am not here.”

She nodded. “Thanks.”

Entrapta closed her eyes and took a deep breath as the pad sounded a third time, centering herself on the feeling of the points of the crystal in her hand once more. When she pressed accept on the screen, she greeted Bow with a toothy, face splitting grin.

“Oh! Hi Bow!” she half shouted at the weary archer.

She could practically *feel* Cobalt’s gaze boring holes in the side of her face.

“Entrapta? Whew, great. For a second there I thought you weren’t going to pick up.”

“Haha, sorry about that!”

“Where are you right now? We said we’d meet up in an hour, remember?”

“Oooh, has it already been that long?” She scratched at her cheek with a lock of hair. “Haha, whoops! I lost track of the time.”

“Ooooooof course you did.” Bow mumbled. “Look, I just met up with Adora out in the desert and we’re heading back to where Swift Wind is resting now.”

“Great! Send me the coordinates and I’ll head your way. Any sign of Glimmer?”

Bow flinched. “Yeah. I found her in the Garnet chamber with Hordak.”

“Oh- really?” Her voice cracked and she cleared her throat before continuing. “So then, she’s with you guys too?”

“No.” Bow glowered. “That green light came from nowhere and they both disappeared before I could reach them.”

“Oh.”

Entrapta swallowed once, twice, and tried to push every intrusive, angry thought rattling around in her head, screeching in raw fury that if she’d just gone with Bow or turned towards the Garnet chamber or figured out how to make the First Ones ship go faster instead of taking a stupid shower, she might have caught Hordak before he’d left.

“Um,” she faltered, stealing a glance at Cobalt who was still watching her intently. “And Scorpia? I, uh, I haven’t seen her anywhere.”

“No, she wasn’t there. Wait, hold on.” Bow looked away from the screen and Entrapta could just barely hear Adora. “Sorry, Adora’s on a call with the others. She says Scorpia is with Perfuma and Frosta out near Plumeria.”

“Oh!” Entrapta’s eyebrows shot up. “Really?”

“Yeah, apparently she connected with the Garnet no problem and wanted to help drive off the Horde.”

“I see. Fascinating.”

She resisted the urge to glance knowingly at Cobalt or acknowledge his disbelieving grunt. Thankfully, Bow wasn’t paying attention anyway.

“Okay, okay- yes, *fine*- I’ll ask.” Bow shot a tired look off screen at Adora. “Hey, Entrapta?”

“Mm?”

“You haven’t seen Catra at all, have you?”

Entrapta looked up at the destroyed room around her and back down at the screen. Bow had seen Hordak but didn’t know about his and Catra’s fight. If he hadn’t seen Catra then did that mean Hordak had been the only one to leave the forge? But then why come to the Garnet chamber instead of going back to the sanctum to recover?

“No.” She made a show of rubbing at her chin with a hair hand. “How strange.”

“Yeah. We were expecting her to show up or get in the way or- I dunno, *something*. You know what she’s like.”

Entrapta broadened her smile and pointedly ignored the throb in her back.

“Sure do. Anyway, be there soon, byeeeee!”

She waved and hung up on Bow before he could reply, not feeling the least bit guilty about it.

Chapter End Notes

I got slightly experimental with the shift to Imp's internal viewpoint and hope it reads smoothly enough. Imp is a super interesting and slightly underutilized character and it can be really difficult to seriously express his thoughts and feelings without making him a POV character (I *almost* made a dedicated Imp chapter but backed out like a coward, haha).

I want to give a HUGE thank you to equivocalEternity for their story Rescue Mission which is a massive inspiration to me. Everything from how Imp's dialogue is expressed to how he thinks and moves was influenced by their work and I genuinely owe them a lot for giving us such a well thought out foundation for his characterization.

Also! Thank you to abneyart for her comics on Imp knowing/learning Sign Language- it's such a wonderful character detail that makes perfect sense and I've been in love with the concept ever since!

My heart and hands collide

Cobalt and Imp were both watching her intently as Entrapta repocketed the data pad and she quashed down the irritable urge to tell them both to stop staring and mind their own business; they were just concerned and didn't deserve her snapping at them. She clasped her hands together behind her back and rocked on her heels instead, feeling like a muddy child caught leaving footprints on the rug under Cobalt's persistent gaze. It didn't come off overly harsh or critical, but his contemplative expression certainly suggested he was thinking very hard about *her* and that was almost never a good thing.

She cleared her throat.

"Sooooo," she started with as much nonchalance as she could muster. "I should probably gooo…"

"What will you do now, Princess?"

"Do? I'm, uh...not sure." Entrapta looked from Cobalt down to the crystal in her hand. "I think...I think I'd like to go find Hordak."

"Do you really believe you can?"

"I don't know, but I feel like I should at least try."

"And what if he doesn't want to be found? If he never actually gave up on returning to his people then don't you think he has finally accomplished his goal?"

"I...I know." She chewed at her lip. "And it's probably childish and selfish and stupid of me, but I want to see him anyway. Even if he decides he doesn't want to come back. I just really want to talk to him and at least let him know what happened. Maybe if I cleared up all the misunderstandings..."

Maybe then he'd want to stay after all.

Cobalt was giving her that look again, the one that made her feel like he could read her mind, and she shuffled in place nervously. The temptation to reach for her mask was growing and she tried to hide her fidgeting by moving to check on Imp. She paused, however, when she saw he'd turned on his perch and caught him in the middle of a nod. A glance over her shoulder confirmed- Cobalt's head was tilted up towards Imp as well.

Oh she did not like whatever silent thing these two were saying to one another *at all*.

Cobalt snapped to attention a moment later and gave her a quick salute.

“Very well, your highness, I understand completely. How may we help?”

Her suspicious squint tilted into unexpected confusion. “Help?”

"Certainly. You did not think we would leave you to such a difficult task without support, did you?"

"W-what?"

“Between your technological prowess and the combined skills and experience of our workforce, I’m sure we can find some way to get you to...wherever Hordak is." Cobalt smirked and his chest puffed up slightly. "The Fright Zone prides itself on its ingenuity and teamwork in the face of overwhelming odds. Even if our resources are limited, I know we can still make your vision a reality.”

Entrapta, wide eyed and slack jawed, was at a complete loss for words.

She didn't have the first clue how to find Hordak, let alone reach him, and yet Cobalt still had this much faith in her? How?

“I appreciate that there are people waiting for you, your highness,” Cobalt continued. “But you don’t have to go with them

if you don’t want to. There *are* other options. You could stay here with us, for example.”

“[-stay here-]” Imp repeated, his little hand slapping against the Garnet’s surface.

“Stay...in the Fright Zone?” she echoed dumbly.

“Your assistance would be greatly appreciated, of course, and your return would likely be a not insignificant morale boost too."

Oh, yes, of course. Her skills would be valuable to them. Yes, that made sense.

Cobalt paused for a moment and his brow furrowed while he struggled to find his words. "I must also admit, I am somewhat...*concerned* for your safety.”

Entrapta blinked at him several times. “M-my safety?”

“I do not trust the other princesses and, at least until we know what Horde Prime wants, I do not think it is wise to rely on the runestone queendoms to do anything other than serve their own interests.”

“So? That’s what they always do.”

“Which is precisely why we must be prepared for the worst- people like us cannot begin to hope for or expect their help.”

“People like...I don’t understand. What does that have to do with me?”

“The Horde protects its own.” He replied, eyebrow raising and tone suggesting this was the most obvious thing in the world.

“But Dryl never joined the Horde.” She shot back, head tilting. “Sure, Hordak and I signed off on some paperwork to establish some trade agreements and a conditional alliance, but I’m not-”

Cobalt waved a hand dismissively. “I don’t mean Dryl- they’re still important and their assistance would be welcome, of course- I’m talking about *you*. *You* are one of us, Princess, and you belong here just as much as I do.”

Imp nodded furiously above them. “[-you belong here-]”

Entrapta’s eyes widened and her shoulders dipped. “I- I can’t- I'm supposed to..."

Imp screeched and she looked up to see him forming an X with his arms, frowning in clear disapproval.

"But...Adora and Bow...the Alliance..."

“I know that we’ve failed you once already,” Cobalt’s head bowed. “I don’t want to make that mistake again.”

“But-" She floundered, not knowing quite how to respond, and clung to the first pathetic argument she could think of. "If Prime really is dangerous, don’t you think this is the first place he would come?”

“Maybe, but I would rather risk you being here, surrounded by capable comrades who can and will stand beside you, than knowingly watch you walk into the hands of people you clearly do not trust.”

Taking a half step back, Entrapta brought her mask down so hard it squashed into her nose. She hardly noticed the stinging, however, as she worked to keep her breathing steady.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

Cobalt’s frown softened into something almost sad. “If there has been one thing that I have learned from looking after the cadets all these years, it is that not all danger is physical, your highness.”

“T-that’s…”

“Princess, please, let us help you. Whatever you need to find and bring Hordak home, I’m sure we can do it.”

She looked down at the scuffed floor, wringing the ends of her hair uncomfortably.

Could they? Could they actually build an entire ship underneath Prime’s very nose and use it to infiltrate his base and rescue Hordak? Was such an audacious thing even possible?

There were a lot of practicalities to consider if they wanted to pull it off. They’d definitely have to leave the Fright Zone- it was too dangerous and with the forge and reactors so badly damaged, any benefit they would have had in staying was gone. Dryl though...yes, they could reroute Grizzlor’s troops in the Whispering Woods and have them meet the rest of the Fright Zone refugees there. Octavia and her crew would have a harder time getting to the mountain region, but Cobalt knew how to mobilize and coordinate people better than anyone she’d ever met, so she was sure he’d know what to do.

Provisions would potentially be an issue; Dryl was rich in mineral resources but the land was heavily contaminated with a variety of metal oxides and particulates and was virtually unusable for farming, although the Fright Zone was unusually well prepared in that regard. The ration bars weren’t exactly delicious or fresh, but they kept well and traveled even better and were both filling and nutritious, so even if Dryl’s granaries and stores were low, they likely wouldn’t go hungry. She didn’t like not knowing her country’s supply ratios, especially considering their near over reliance on easily disrupted trade routes, but there was nothing for it- the last time she’d spoken with her ministers had been two days before she’d been exiled to Beast Island. She had faith that they’d kept things running smoothly enough in her absence, but she really needed to contact them soon and get a full update.

The castle itself was excellently positioned, hidden deep within a notoriously treacherous range of mountains, and with the Fright Zone soldiers there to help shore up defenses, Entrapta was

confident they could hold their position in Dryl for an extended period of time. Between its myriad traps, sturdy construction, and maze of tunnels, no one in recorded history had ever successfully taken Crypto Castle, not even Mystacor, and most ground assaults had never even made it to the front gates.

Entrapta's eyes were drawn to the ships above them.

It was harder to say, however, how well the castle could hold against an aerial assault- Mystacorian Mages had a few floating tricks but nothing to the scale of what Prime clearly had. Although the network of magic dampeners embedded in the mines and mountains of Dryl was generally more than enough to deter and stop malicious magic users when activated, there was no guarantee Horde Prime's forces worked magic- in fact, if Hordak's sour attitude towards it was anything to go off of, they likely didn't at all.

Admittedly, they also had very little idea what kinds of weaponry the Galactic Horde was carrying or if they shared Hordak's reservations towards leveling entire mountains, but still, Crypto Castle was relatively safe, well hidden, tighter and more defendable than most locations in Etheria, and had her lab filled with equipment and resources and the bulk of her impressive collection of First Ones artifacts. She could take Hordak's research and files there with her, along with whatever other equipment she could salvage from her room and the sanctum, and they could build the ship in secret- in the ballroom, maybe? It wasn't like it ever got used anyway.

Yes, the more she thought of it, Entrapta was sure that it could work- going to Dryl would buy them much needed time and even if they did have to sacrifice the castle, the mines ran deep into the earth and spilled out into dozens of different places, providing a variety of reliable escape routes. Push come to shove, they could transfer the work somewhere else- maybe the Crimson Wastes? The signal she'd picked up out there had turned out to be Adora's First Ones ship, so it wasn't like it was actually all that empty. After all, Catra had returned with new friends and Scorpia had

been telling her stories of the people that lived there before things had gone sideways. It seemed like the next best place- a hostile location, naturally resistant to invasion with a reputation of being deserted and, thus, unappealing to go to. The sand and the heat would be hell to work with, but that would be a problem for future Entrapta to solve.

This was all, of course, working under the assumption that she could actually manage to build a craft fit for travel to a place she had incomplete data on with next to no time to run proper testing, little to no chance for proof-of-concept runs, and with exceptionally limited examples to pull from. It was one thing to sit at Hordak's desk and draft out fantastical ideas that were about as scientifically reliable as Imp's doodling beside her, but it was something entirely different to try and actually whip up the most complex creation of her life over a metaphorical weekend. It wasn't just reasonable to assume she couldn't do it without years of work, it was painfully likely; child prodigy she might have been, miracle worker she certainly was not.

Entrapta bowed her head and rubbed at her chin.

Alright then, she needed a plan B.

What if she stole one of the Galactic Horde's ships? Surely they wouldn't miss *one* little ship, especially if they made it look like an accident or a crash or something. She had no idea how their ships worked but she wanted to crack it open and take a look inside anyway, so surely she could figure something out. Maybe Hordak had an old user manual tucked away in his personal database?

Hordak *had* once mentioned that his old ship used a combination of haptic technology and a direct connection into his neural ports- she could still clearly remember how amused he'd been when she'd suggested trying to pilot one someday. When he'd started outright laughing at her insistence that she could do it, she'd nearly accused him of being mean for making fun of her until she realized how warm his expression was. He'd tried his best to explain himself, of course, but she'd been so distracted by how

relaxed his smile was and how rich his voice sounded that she'd hardly absorbed a word of what he'd said. Even now, recalling the moment, the flutter in her stomach made it difficult to think of anything else- what had he said the problem was? Something about the neural connection being required? Or the system itself being exponential and unmannable by a single individual? Genetic locking codes? She'd been recording at the time- it was too bad she didn't have the file on her, she could have checked.

It would have been nice to hear Hordak's laugh again too.

Entrapta flushed and shook her head. She needed to focus- now was not the time for...whatever *that* was.

Irregardless of what the issue actually would be, there was still strong enough reason to believe she wouldn't be able to just pilot whatever they stole. She could certainly try her usual method of hijacking and reprogramming the system, but if that wasn't enough and they needed to adjust the hardware too? Well, if the system really was as complicated as Hordak had made it sound, that could take just as long as building a ship from scratch.

Okaaay, plan C.

Hm.

Head still down, Entrapta started idly meandering around the room, dozens of hair ends pulling away from the bunch to twist and twirl in tiny circles.

There was…

Well...

She *could*...

What if she just sort of... *took* Adora's ship?

Yeah?

Too late to turn back / Only fate's left to decide

Chapter Notes

> More worldbuilding this chapter, this time featuring tons of references to the original 80s show! Full disclosure, I haven't actually seen more than a few clips and screencaps of the original show, so the references are basically fun name drops and nods towards characters like Mantenna who never got an official glow-up; here's hoping my wiki diving did them justice!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Entrapta hummed to herself, continuing her pacing as she rubbed at her chin.

Okay, okay, *sure*, taking Adora's ship after they'd just rescued her sounded kind of... *bad*, even to her, but it wasn't like they really even needed it, right?

Really, what were they even going to use it for, anyway? Brightmoon and the other queendoms had *lots* of ways to get around and Adora, especially, had her flying horse so a space ship would only be taking up room! Getting in the way! She'd be doing them a favor!

Besiiiiides, Bow could barely fly the thing and it wasn't like anyone in Brightmoon knew how to fix it. A precious artifact like that would be a total waste in their hands anyway, so, really, it just made logical sense that they give it to Etheria's leading authority on First Ones technology. That was how things worked, right? Division of labor? Giving everyone tasks they were best suited for? That kind of thing.

After all, you don't ask the ice princess to grow a garden or the light bending princess to move oceans, so it only made sense that

she inherit the technical machinery since that was her specialty.

Entrapta pursed her lips and nodded to herself.

Yes, yes, this really was the correct solution. She takes the First Ones ship, the Fright Zoners dig in at Crypto Castle and assist her until she's finished with repairs, and Adora and Bow and the rest of the Alliance focus on protecting their queendoms. Then, when the ship was ready, she'd set off for space with Imp and they rescue Hordak.

And Glimmer too, she supposed, while they're there.

May as well.

Ah yes, what a perfectly nice and tidy solution that benefited everyone!

Sure, there was the sticky matter of figuring out where Hordak and Glimmer were...and actually getting to them. Also how to infiltrate a massive army the size of which no Etherian had ever seen without being detected. Or what she'd do if she got caught. Or if the ship broke down.

But there was no reason to get pessimistic about the situation!

Heck, maybe if she just called up Bow now and asked nicely, he'd just give her the ship and leave the whole thing to her.

Of course, they'd probably want to tag along...or outright deny her. *That* would be a real pain: then they'd be on high alert and expecting her to come and steal it anyway.

Which, to be fair, she absolutely would.

"What? Did you think friendship was easy?"

Admittedly, just taking the ship, especially after asking and being told no, *would* be kind of... *rude*.

And, well...

Even if they only did it because they wanted something from her, they *did* rescue her from Beast Island and they *did* take her almost immediately to the Fright Zone, even if they hadn't intended on her spending the time looking for Hordak (which, really, stupid move on their part, if they knew her even half as well as they claimed then they should have expected that from her by now). Taking all of that into consideration, she probably *ought* to give them something in exchange as a token of gratitude.

Like not stealing their ship even though she really, reeeeeally wanted to.

"It takes work to be there for other people. It takes everything you've got!"

Damn it. That was probably the ethically correct thing to do, even if it was incredibly annoying.

The lenses of her mask fogged as she let out a puff of frustrated air.

"Okaaaay, back to plan B then." Entrapta muttered softly. "Steal one of Prime's ships..."

There was a problem with that though: if she left the First Ones ship with the Alliance, they were almost guaranteed to go looking for Glimmer.

That wasn't so much an issue on its own, per se, but even if they somehow managed to break Etheria's atmosphere without the ship falling apart, there was basically no way Bow and Adora would make it to Prime's location. They had no idea what a sun was, let alone solar winds or radiation or decompression sickness or- well, point was, they knew even less about space than she did and there was no way they'd have any clue how to prepare for or protect themselves from the unforgiving environment.

No matter how you cut it, they'd absolutely die in the attempt without her help and they didn't deserve that.

Besides, redundancy was all well and good, but two Etherian ships wouldn't make a difference in the grand scheme of things and there really was no point in dividing their resources and attention like that or taking such an obscenely unnecessary risk. Knowing that the Alliance would definitely send out the First Ones ship instead of using it to protect Brightmoon or something (did the craft even *have* weapon functionality?), it really just made her building or reprogramming a Galactic Horde ship of her own a total waste of time.

The Alliance would undoubtedly be trying to figure out the best way to protect their lands, just like Cobalt said, which meant Cobalt and the other Fright Zoners would need to focus on keeping themselves safe too. As much as she hated to admit it, her taking them to Dryl for what was effectively a vanity project would just pull them away from more critically important tasks like protecting the civilian population or helping the other Lesser Court Queendoms with shoring up their defenses.

That wasn't even taking into account the other territories and low stakes land claims typically ignored by the Runestone Queens. She knew for sure Peekablue would do his best to help Sweet Bee with the Andreenids and the other island peoples out between Salineas and the Queendom of Snows, but there was no telling if his farsight would really give them enough of an edge to hold their lands and not just run away. She sincerely doubted they'd be considered high priority targets, but still...

What about the others?

Nearly all of the varieties of Elf population were protected under the larger Queendoms and she could proudly say the ones in Dryl were hearty and well prepared for a variety of disasters. The Taurans were similarly scattered but unlikely to experience much issue so long as Brightmoon and Plumeria held. There *were* the Canids out in the badlands (and apparently the Crimson Wastes),

but they were strong and organized and she had no doubt they'd manage on their own just as they usually did. Just past the badlands though...hm, King Agho would be hard pressed to protect Spikeheart, even with the Geolons there to help. Unless the fiercely independent Silaxians came to his aid he'd *need* assistance from the Fright Zone if they were to stand any chance of not losing the entire valley and range and perfectly setting up an invading army's forces to march out on the badlands, marshes, and Wastes.

Entrapta stopped short, looking out past the jagged edges of the destroyed wall across the pink lens-tinged city skyline and the stars above them. The tiny pin pricks of light blurred as her eyes started to water and, for the first time since leaving Brightmoon, the evening air felt biting and unforgiving instead of pleasantly cool.

She could see it so clearly in her mind's eye-

-crafting parts side by side with Adamantia again-

-translating Grizzlor's almost boyish ideas into improved weapons for him to protect them all with-

-Octavia and Cobalt and the Force Captains, keeping things organized and running smoothly-

-Imp causing trouble everywhere he went and always finding new ways to make her laugh-

-awkward little Kyle and his squad mates and the rest of the soldiers, singing and carousing in the great hall over Drylian mead-

It would be so much fun.

She could see her robots again and her staff were probably worried sick about her (what would Baker make of Cookie in all of his grubby glory?) and, although she wasn't exactly friends with

basically any of the Drylian townspeople, it would still be nice to see their familiar faces again.

Even with war bearing down on them all, how amazing would it be to take the sense of belonging and community Cobalt was offering her here and merge it with the place she'd always known as home?

Her heart swelled with that fuzzy warmth and giddiness she'd felt when she'd first reentered the Fright Zone- swinging with wild abandon throughout its inner workings until she'd almost, truly believed everything could go back to the way they'd been before.

"And we never gave up on you, even when you were with the Horde."

But...

It was too late for things to go back. No one could undo what had happened.

She'd helped cause this mess, so didn't that mean she had a duty to fix it?

Prime wouldn't have found them if she'd just said something to Hordak sooner, had stopped him or shared her worries or- or...*something*.

Salineas wouldn't be destroyed if she'd just remembered to watch her back and kept her stupid mouth shut. Hordak never would have gone on his rampage if she'd just acted as smart as she claimed she was.

She'd *known* better than to mention Adora in front of Catra, so really, it was her own fault she'd ended up on Beast Island.

What right did she have to avoid facing the consequences of her poor decisions?

It was one thing to engineer weapons to be used by Etheria's non-magical population to even the odds in open combat against the terrifying elemental force of the princesses, but she'd never meant for her portal to be used to collapse reality or her First Ones research to yield a planet destroying super weapon.

Except...good intentions really didn't mean anything. No matter her reasons, she couldn't just run and hide away in Dryl with the Fright Zoners and stealing the First Ones ship would be just as bad.

Letting Etheria's real heroes fly themselves straight into a death trap would be even worse.

"Because that's what friends do."

Entrapta groaned and scrubbed at her face, the backs of her gloves catching now and again against the edges of her mask.

No matter how badly she wanted it, she couldn't go through with any of these plans.

Or shouldn't.

Uuuuuuhg.

Entrapta sighed and turned back to Cobalt, unsurprised to see him and Imp both watching her intently.

"I can't." she said, pulling her mask back. "Stay, I mean."

"Princess, if it's something we've done wr-"

"It's not you guys-" Her shoulders dropped. "I just...can't."

"I don't understand."

"I *want* to stay, I do, but Adora already has a First Ones spaceship. It's in pretty bad shape and in desperate need of repairs. I'm not even sure if it'll hold together once we leave the

atmosphere, but they'll want to go find Glimmer anyway and Hordak is probably wherever she is, so if I go with them…"

Cobalt frowned. "I don't see how that prevents us from also making an attempt."

Imp nodded vigorously down at them.

"That's the thing, even if we could do it, the chances we'd get caught are through the roof and no matter how many ways I run through it in my head, I just can't see a way to justify us making our own ship when Etheria needs you guys to help defend it."

"You would...rather we put our efforts elsewhere?"

Entrapta shrugged, hair following the motion for emphasis.

"You guys can't do what you're good at if you're busy doing things for me."

Cobalt opened his mouth to reply but was cut off by the door sliding open behind him and Kyle stepping through. He hummed softly in annoyance and turned to the younger man.

"Report."

"Sir!" Kyle clicked his heels together and brought his fist up to his chest in salute. "All orders have been relayed successfully sir."

Cobalt nodded and Kyle continued, reading off his data pad.

"We finally heard back from the naval unit."

Cobalt perked up. "Yes?"

"Nearly half the fleet was sunk by the Princess of Salineas and the other half's grounded. The Admiral is tied up in rescue and recovery operations right now but her second said he'd get her to contact you as soon as she's deck-side again."

Cobalt nodded grimly and Entrapta couldn't help but notice how tightly he gripped his tablet.

"We don't have a casualty count yet but," Kyle faltered and rubbed at the back of his neck. "More than a few crew members are believed lost. Apparently the princess was striking hard, especially just before the weird light show."

Cobalt sighed. "Out for blood after the strike on the capital, no doubt."

Kyle nodded. "Yes sir. Mayor Mantenna called as well."

"Of course." Cobalt's eyes closed for the briefest moment and there was an air of self-admonishment to his voice when he spoke. "Are they alright?"

"He mostly wanted information. Apparently they went on alert when they detected the explosions here in the military zone. As far as anyone's been able to tell, the crater shell protected them from any stray blasts like usual."

"Good."

"The Mayor said the council motioned to put the city under protective lockdown when the sky started doing all that weird stuff. Most everyone was sheltered by the time those ships showed up and they didn't seem to have any problems."

Cobalt sighed softly. "At least one thing has gone right today."

"He kept pressing Lonnie for information so she told him the explosions were a false alarm but that further information is still pending and that you would contact him at your earliest convenience, sir."

"Good. What else?"

"Um, let's see, Councilwoman Pointessa is on hold on line 3. Lonnie told her several times that you were busy and she'd

probably be waiting for awhile, but she wants to talk to Lord Hordak and refuses to hang up until she does."

"I assume the Force Captain told her the same thing she said to Mantenna?"

"Yes sir but the Councilwoman insisted. She said she'd wait on the phone all night if she had to."

"That certainly sounds like the General." Cobalt muttered. "Even as a civil servant she hasn't lost her sting."

Cobalt glanced her way and Entrapta raised a brow, smiling wryly at them.

"See what I mean?"

"I suppose you have a point."

Kyle's head swiveled back and forth between them several times.

"Did, uh, something happen while I was gone?"

"No," Cobalt replied. "The Princess was just preparing to leave."

"O-oh…" Kyle looked down for a moment, his voice tinged a little hopeful as he looked at Entrapta. "But I thought you were going to stay?"

"Not this time." She replied. "I've got work to do and so do you guys."

"Because we're not ever going to leave you behind again!"

"Besides," Entrapta continued, trying her best to sound more upbeat than she felt. "there are some people waiting for me and I don't want them causing you guys more trouble if they decide to come back, looking for me."

She'd already stayed too long as it was; Bow was going to be so irritated with her. She knew she'd feel bad about it later and she'd

try to make it up to him, but right now she couldn’t bring herself to care; she’d waited ten whole months to be here, he could wait a few more minutes.

“Um!” Kyle squeaked. “If you’re leaving Princess, then can I ask you a quick question?”

“Mm?”

“Is, uh, is Adora doing okay?”

“Huh?”

“Well, you know, we used to be squad mates and all, and I, uh, well, I know she left and the others were pretty mad about that but...I dunno, I still kind of worry about her sometimes.”

Entrapta’s head tilted. “You’re...worried about her?”

“Well, yeah. She was usually really nice to me and, well, I don't know if she feels the same, exactly, but I always kind of felt like she was sort of like my big sister? I can be kind of a screw up sometimes-"

"Cadet," Cobalt's eyes narrowed. "What have I said about talk like that?"

"Sir!" Kyle yelped. "That it's a self-fulfilling prophecy that doesn't help anyone, sir."

"Precisely." The larger man nodded. "Now, try again."

"Yes sir. Um," Kyle's shoulders drooped a little as he rubbed the back of his head. "Well, I guess, what I mean is, I struggled a lot and Adora was one of the people whose teasing felt, I dunno, inviting instead of mean? She'd help Rogelio look out for me and ran off bullies with Lonnie and, heck, even *Catra* was almost kind of fun with Adora around, but sometimes I worry nobody's looking out for her. I mean, you know what’s she’s like? How she, uh…I don’t really know how to...” Kyle trailed off, floundering.

Cobalt nodded, placing a sympathetic hand on Kyle's shoulder. "Adora has a bad habit of taking on too much and thinking she has to protect everyone on her own. She often overworks herself and holds herself to unreasonable standards and expectations out of a misplaced fear of being a burden."

Kyle looked up at Cobalt. "Aaaaaw, Commander! You *do* care!"

Cobalt's warm expression immediately soured but Entrapta thought she could see a faint flush under the thinner fur around his face.

"Do you really think, after all this time, I would not?"

Kyle cracked a weak smile at the glowering man. "Well, no, but you can be kind of scary sometimes, sir."

Entrapta giggled at the two of them, drawing their attention. "Well, I'm not totally sure, but for the couple hours I saw her, Adora seemed like she was doing okay to me."

Kyle let out a relieved sigh. "Oh, that's good."

"Y'know, funny enough," Entrapta continued thoughtfully. "She was just talking about you a few hours ago, Commander."

"She...was?"

"Mhm. She was patching up somebody's wound and bragging about all the stuff she learned from you; it seemed like a happy memory."

Cobalt's mouth dropped and he blinked owlishly at her. At first Entrapta wondered if she'd said something wrong but, when she saw how Cobalt's pointed ears dipped the same way Hordak's did when he was incredibly pleased or happy about something, she decided that, even though they were very difference species, that was still likely a good thing.

Chapter End Notes

Okay, okay, I know the Dad!Hordak/Hordad concept is pretty popular and I respect the classic 80s show and how it handled his relationship with Adora, but for the 2018 show I would like to instead offer you all Commander Cobalt as the Fright Zone Dad of the Year.

Cobalt has not only been looking after a bunch of angsty teenagers since they were shit children, but an even angstier spacebat going through his punk goth/bad breakup phase as well. Poor Commander Dad- he just wants his children to be happy and successful but they keep running away from home or attempting to collapse reality. At least Kyle and Rogelio are good boys with their heads mostly on straight. Lonnie's going through some tough stuff right now and rebelling a little, but Cobalt's still very proud of her and knows she's a damn good kid and she's going to be just fine.

Magnum bullets / Settling a score

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Giving Cobalt a moment to recompose himself while Kyle awkwardly patted his arm, Entrapta looked around the room one last time, trying to decide the best means of leaving. The door seemed the obvious answer, of course, but why go through the Fright Zone's twisting hallways when she could just go *over* them all? That seemed the most efficient method in this situation...

Above her, Imp chirped excitedly and glided down from the Black Garnet, settling himself between Entrapta's pigtails. He looked down at her, curling over her head and poking into view upside down in front of her, and pointed a thumb over his shoulder.

"Huh?"

"[Let's move people!]" he said in a voice she didn't recognize.

"Wha- Oh. *Oh*..." She bit her lip and twin tails reached up to gently lift the small creature, shifting his pliant form to cradle him in front of her. "No, Imp. I- you...you can't come with me."

It nearly broke her heart to see his mouth drop open and his yellow eyes widen, shock and hurt written plain as day across his face as he stared up at her.

"I know, it's not fair, but-"

Uninterested, Imp screeched angrily and struggled against her hair, but she knew better- if he got free now he'd just hide somewhere until she gave up and then follow her back to Brightmoon anyway. He'd used that tactic against her and Hordak dozens of times before when he disliked what they said or did, but she couldn't let him get away with it this time. Imp growled but she held tight, strands wrapping carefully around his limbs and

trapping his wings and tail. He struggled valiantly against her but exhaustion won out eventually and, both of them panting from exertion, Imp glared up at her. He considered her for a long moment as he caught his breath before smirking wickedly.

“[What did you say?]” he replied in Hordak’s voice. She flinched; that was a dirty shot and they both knew it.

“I-I’m sorry.”

He squawked back and started chewing at her hair.

“Ah! Hey! Cut that out!”

Her grip on him began to loosen as she tried to remove the rope of hair he’d chomped down on and he took the opportunity to attempt to escape once more. She shouted wordlessly and just barely grabbed him in time by the back of his suspenders. Imp hissed and squeaked at her and she could feel her eyes welling up in response to his frustrated struggles.

“I’m really sorry Imp, I want to take you with me but I *can’t*.”

He glowered up at her. “[Liar!]”

“No! I’m not- please, Imp, it’s too dangerous! We have no idea what’s going to happen and I’m going to be right in the middle of all of it!"

He pulled against the confines of her hair to cross his arms, lip jutted out in an expert pout.

"Oh, come on, don't look at me like that! What if we got separated? What if something happened to you?”

Imp chattered angrily, shaking his head and pointing harshly at her.

“Do you have any idea how upset Hordak would be if you were hurt?”

She held out Hordak's power crystal to Imp and he froze, his eyes widening once more. Entrapta unwound her hair from his arm as it tugged lightly to be free, letting him reach out and touch the crystal in her palm.

"You're the most important person in the whole world to him, I can't let that happen," she said softly.

His little shoulders fell and Entrapta brought him closer to herself, unwinding her hair and pulling Imp into a proper hug. His arms circled her neck and he nuzzled his face against her cheek and collar. She could feel dampness against her skin and she rubbed soothing circles into the back of his head as she looked up questioningly at the soldiers staring at them.

"You guys *will* look after him for me, won't you?"

Recovering first, Cobalt cleared his throat and elbowed Kyle, cutting off the younger man's high pitched "aaaaw!"

"Of course we will, your highness."

Entrapta nodded appreciatively at Cobalt and looked back down at Imp, kissing the top of his hair. When the little clone looked up at her in surprise she lightly bumped his forehead with hers.

"I promise I'll find him and bring that stupid idiot home," she whispered. "Until then, will you go with them? So I'll know where to find you later?"

Imp nodded slowly and she smiled at him.

"I know you'll be safe with them and, besides, we both know they're going to need your help. No one can gather information or cause trouble like you."

He cracked a slight smile in response and she kissed his forehead once more. Imp gave her one last tight hug and pulled away, flying over to Cobalt and settling on his broad shoulders. Entrapta had half expected Cobalt to grunt or exclaim in surprised but the

two of them simply exchanged curt nods and she couldn't help but wonder if they didn't already have some kind of arrangement or understanding.

She rubbed at her arms and curled her toes in her boots, missing Imp already. She hated to leave him here, but it was the right thing to do.

Cobalt looked to her once more, snapping into a salute. Kyle immediately followed suit.

"Your highness," Cobalt said. "I regret that we did not investigate your disappearance more thoroughly. I have always known Lord Hordak to be a careful and diligent man so when he told us you had betrayed us, I could not think of a reason to doubt him, no matter how upsetting it was. Many of us among the officers felt like something was wrong and we should have listened to our instincts and followed up anyway. Much of our current predicament might have been mitigated if we had and I wish to formally apologize for failing you so miserably in your hour of need."

Entrapta gasped softly as Cobalt carefully bowed to her while balancing Imp on his shoulder. He straightened a moment later and continued on as she stared at him, dumbfounded.

"Nevertheless, I am relieved you are alright and I know many of the others will be as well. The Fright Zone has not felt the same since your previous departure and you have been sorely missed."

Entrapta swallowed several times, her mouth suddenly dry and eyes stinging once more.

"Thank you," she said softly. "...for everything."

"Good luck, your highness. We look forward to your safe return."

"Yeah, safe travels princess!" Kyle grinned.

She nodded and pulled her mask down. With one last look at Imp, curling a tendril of hair in return to his half-hearted wave, she lifted herself up onto her hair and made her way for the wall with the deepest piece missing, carefully clambering over its edge and hanging off its side.

Finding a good place a few feet down to partially stand, she paused to wipe at the tears in her eyes. Behind her she could faintly hear Cobalt and Kyle speaking and tried to focus on their voices to calm down; it wouldn't do if she slipped and broke her neck now, after everything that had happened, just because she was feeling a little emotional.

"-with the others and get some rest while you can. Have someone go relieve Lonnie as well; she's been working hard and deserves a break."

"Who should I send sir?"

"You know the job and what it takes; I trust your judgment."

Kyle's squeaky affirmative was filled with pride.

"I'll head that way soon," Cobalt continued. "Clearly, I have a few phone calls to make first."

Entrapta wiped at her face one last time as Kyle affirmed again. She started looking around at the crumbling ledges and damaged pipe working below her, plotting out a prospective path as the Garnet Chamber door distantly swooshed open and closed again. She'd very nearly decided on a route (she had to be sure to test *that* pipe *before* resting her weight on it, the welding looked loose but it was hard to tell in the evening light) but a choked sound above her gave her pause.

"-o glad you're okay."

Curiosity winning out, Entrapta turned and carefully picked her way back up the ledge, peering just over the rim back into the Garnet Chamber. Cobalt was alone, turned mostly away from her

and sitting on a piece of rubble. He had his forehead resting in the palm of one hand, leaning against his knee, and his data pad clutched in the other. She thought she could just barely make out the partially obscured visage of General Grizzlor on the screen, looking up at Cobalt with an unusual expression of raw worry.

She squinted and thought she could see Grizzlor's mouth moving, but couldn't hear him.

"Then you heard about 'Tavia's- yes, as far as we know she's alright but- I know. I…" Cobalt paused as Grizzlor spoke. "It's worse than that…Hordak's *gone*." Cobalt flinched and Entrapta could hear Grizzlor's tinny expletive from where she was hiding. "It's complicated Grizz, but- no- we can't rely on her either- she's a traitor."

Grizzlor's head tilted and he mouthed a "what" so clear, she could practically hear it from where she was hiding.

"She sent Entrapta to Beast Island. Scorpia saw the whole thing."

Grizzlor's confusion melted into incredulity.

"I don't know why she sat on it for so long- I- no, I can't *ask* her, Scorpia's gone over to the Rebellion-"

Another, slightly louder string of expletives blasted from Cobalt's earpiece.

"I know, I know. I can't figure out why she wouldn't just come talk to us either-" Cobalt's shoulders started trembling and Entrapta could see the man palming at his eyes. "It might not matter anyway. There's a significant chance the Fright Zone's compromised and- and-"

Cobalt's voice cracked.

"Grizz, I don't know what to do."

Entrapta swallowed and turned away. She'd never heard the stalwart man sound so scared; he'd always been so grounded and task focused, she'd half believed he didn't know what the word 'fear' even meant.

Behind her, she could hear Cobalt take several shuddering breaths.

She had to go. This wasn't right.

She shouldn't be seeing or hearing any of this. She was intruding on something raw and private and definitely not for her.

Entrapta picked her way down, not stopping until her feet hit solid ground. It felt wrong to leave Cobalt on his own like that and she wished there was something she could do, some way of comforting him in return for his kindness, but she couldn't think of a single thing that wouldn't cause more problems. The best she could do now was protect his dignity and give him his privacy.

Grizzlor was there for him; she had to have faith in that.

Reaching the edge of the Fright Zone, Entrapta took one last look back at the sprawling mass of the industrial and military zones that had become her home away from home, at the stars above them and the army that floated among their light.

No matter what was coming, no matter what happened, she swore to herself that she'd protect them all- the Drylians, Cobalt and the Fright Zoners, Adora and Bow and the rest of the princesses- all of them.

She was going to find Hordak and she was going to bring him back home to Imp, kicking and screaming if she had to.

She'd helped create this mess and she was going to set things right.

No matter what it took.

Chapter End Notes

hops in her little tug boat and toots the horn All aboard the Cobalt/Grizzlor ship, population: actually, literally just me. (What even is this ship name? Coblor? Grizzbalt? Fur Dads?)

Our final art credit goes to proxie-of-the-art! Although it's the first page of an AU project that appears to be abandoned, I'm in love with how determined Entrapta looks and thought about it surprisingly often while writing this story.

Speaking of determination, as some of you may have started to guess, Electric Tapestry has a built in theme song: "Magnum Bullets" by Nightrunner+Dan Avidan! I hadn't originally intended to tie a song to the story, but as I was writing I found myself coming back to it time and again and it always got me into exactly the right mood to write. Not only does the synth match up pretty nicely with SPoP's general soundtrack, but I feel like the music video really captures the same tragic loss and determined anger I imagined Entrapta feeling once she left Beast Island. If you haven't seen the music video, then please go treat yourself and check it out; it's stunning!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!